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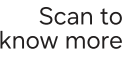
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CAUVERY BASIN DISTRESS

CWMA tells States to maintain *status quo*

SOUTH » PAGE 7

FOSTERING MULTIPOLARITY

Jaishankar meets Wang, stresses stable ties

NEWS » PAGE 12



TWO-YEAR WINDOW

Trump warns of 200% tax on drug imports

BUSINESS » PAGE 13



LOST FAITH

Time to trust States as NEET's promise fails

The protests reflect a deeper crisis: Stalin

OPINION » PAGE 9

SPORTING CARNIVAL

23rd Commonwealth Games from today

SPORT » PAGE 15



NEARBY



Case filed against 3 hospitals over kidney racket

CHENNAI Health Minister K.G. Arunraj has said that a case had been filed in the Namakkal Judicial Magistrate Court against three hospitals and doctors involved in a kidney racket. » PAGE 6

Bail plea of Vilathikulam MLA rejected

THOOTHUKUDI A court here has dismissed the bail plea of Vilathikulam MLA, G.V. Markandayan, who was held for making allegedly threatening remarks against the Chief Minister. » PAGE 6

Breakfast scheme renamed after ex-CM Kamaraj

CHENNAI The Chief Minister's Breakfast Scheme has been renamed after former Chief Minister K. Kamaraj. It will now be known as Perunthalaivar Kamarajar Breakfast Scheme. » PAGE 6

METROPLUS » 4 PAGES

Delhi HC seeks govt. response on police actions during CJP march

Petitioners warn against unchecked police action, flag use of lathis with nails, electric batons, pellet guns during the July 20 protest march; allegations can't be dismissed as 'isolated incidents', says court; it orders preservation of CCTV, video footage

Soibam Rocky Singh
NEW DELHI

The Delhi High Court on Wednesday asked the Centre and the Delhi Police to respond to a batch of public interest litigation (PIL) petitions alleging that the police used excessive force against students and other protesters during the Parliament march called by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) on July 20.

A Bench of Chief Justice D.K. Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia observed that the allegations could not be brushed aside as "isolated incidents", and ordered that all relevant material, including CCTV footage and videography, related to the march be preserved in accordance with the standard operating procedures of the Delhi Police.

Appearing for one of the petitioners, senior advocate N. Hariharan alleged that the protesters were subjected to "brutality to the largest extent" by the state machinery. "There are videos of several people in civil clothes carrying lathis, lathis with nails, electric batons, and pellet guns. There is not a whisp-



Staying put: CJP protesters at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi on Wednesday. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

er that anybody in the march was violent," he submitted.

Mr. Hariharan further alleged that some policemen could be seen molesting women. "There are policemen molesting women, using baton... It is so ghastly," he said, seeking the registration of FIRs against identifiable officers, and a high-level inquiry into the incident. According to him, more than 90 people had suffered injuries, with the number continuing to rise.

Senior advocate Gopal

Sankaranarayanan, appearing in one of the petitions, alleged that a large number of police personnel were deployed without nameplates and they used batons not authorised by the Delhi Police. Warning against unchecked police action, Mr. Sankaranarayanan submitted, "If constitutional courts do not intervene, it would amount to giving the police a licence to get away with anything because they have the sanction of their political masters."

Additional Solicitor-

General S.V. Raju alleged that the agitation had turned violent, with the protesters throwing stones and injuring police personnel. Lawyers representing the petitioners, however, said the police action was unwarranted and brutal, warning that the courts must step in to hold the police accountable.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10
EDITORIAL
» PAGE 8
DON'T WASTE OUR TIME: CJI
» PAGE 10

Ministers meet Wangchuk as govt. steps up outreach

NEW DELHI The Centre on Wednesday moved up a notch its engagement with protesters against the NEET paper leak, with Union Ministers J.P. Nadda and Jitendra Singh meeting activist Sonam Wangchuk, who responded from hospital with a statement that he was willing to call off the hunger strike if the government gave an assurance that no punitive action would be taken against the protesting students. » PAGE 10

Rahul seeks to mollify allies, put pressure on govt.

NEW DELHI Opposition needs to step up pressure on the government, Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi said on Wednesday as he reassured INDIA bloc allies that the Congress believes in better coordination between them. His remarks came as several allies were reportedly upset over not being kept in the loop about the Congress's dharna at the Prime Minister's residence. » PAGE 11

10 more deaths raise Assam flood toll to 41

Rahul Karmakar
GUWAHATI

The Assam government on Wednesday said the ongoing wave of floods in some eastern districts of the State has been the worst in 60 years, affecting more than 6.5 lakh people and claiming 41 lives in less than a month.

According to a late-night bulletin by the Assam State Disaster Management Authority (ASDMA), floodwaters claimed the lives of 10 people across five districts during the last 24 hours.

Meanwhile, the number of flood-affected districts reduced from 16 to 11 during this period.

"The floods have affect-



People wade through a waterlogged road in Golaghat, Assam, on Wednesday. PTI

ed 6,53,164 people across 939 villages and crops on 24,897.27 hectares of land. The district authorities have set up 106 relief camps, where 24,418 people have taken shelter," an ASDMA spokesperson said.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

TVK remains firm on abolition of NEET: CM

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Chief Minister and TVK founder C. Joseph Vijay on Wednesday said his party remained firm in its stand that NEET should be abolished.

In a post on X, Mr. Vijay condemned the Union government for detaining Leader of the Opposition

in the Lok Sabha and Congress leader Rahul Gandhi and others, who staged a protest against question paper leaks, and for education reforms, in front of the Prime Minister's residence in New Delhi on Tuesday.

Terming the detention of the leaders "anti-democratic", he said his party extended full support to the protest.



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Muthulakshmi Reddy’s house to be renovated by Cancer Institute

Sri Arunachaleswarar Devasthanam, which owns the land where the house is located, gives nod to the institute to carry out the renovation

Deepta H. Ramakrishnan
CHENNAI

Work to renovate Muthulakshmi Reddy’s stately home located in Adyar will begin soon. Dr. Reddy was the country’s first woman medical graduate and the first woman to enter Indian legislature. Steps to start work on renovation has become possible after the Tiruvannamalai Sri Arunachaleswarar Devasthanam, which owns the land on which the building is located, took steps to implement a Madras High Court order permitting the Cancer Institute (W.I.A.) to renovate the house. Dr. Reddy, the force behind the founding of the Cancer Institute in Adyar, and founder of Avvai Home for Girls, lived there for over 30 years from 1936.

The building is in run-down condition and needs urgent attention. The land on which it sits belongs to the Tiruvannamalai Sri Arunachaleswarar temple and had been taken on lease by her. She built the Avvai Home, her home, and two small shrines - one for Lord Ganesha and another for Saraswathi Devi.

Author V.R. Devika, who has written a book on Dr. Reddy and had been pursuing the cause of renovating the building, said that when the lease time ended, the temple wanted to



Fresh life: Muthulakshmi Reddy, the country’s first woman medical graduate, lived in the house at Adyar for 30 years from 1936.

increase the lease rent. But a free school for girls could not afford the rent. Later, a new home and a school was built on a piece of land given by former Chief Minister M.G. Ramachandran.

Ms. Devika said that Dr. Krishnamurthy, son of Dr. Reddy, had sold personal property of 32 grounds on LB Road and created the Ramakrishna - Vivekananda Trust for use by the Cancer Institute and the Avvai Home. Funds from this trust will be utilised for renovation of her bungalow.

V. Susheela, honorary secretary of Avvai Home, thanked the Arunachaleswarar Temple authorities and HR&CE Secretary J. Kumaragurubaran for handing over the building to the Cancer Institute for renovating it and maintaining it as a memorial for Dr. Reddy. “We have drawings from architects ready with

us. In the building, we will have an exhibition on Dr. Reddy and a space for small gatherings. It will be the responsibility of the Cancer Institute to maintain the surrounding space too”.

Chairman of Avvai Home N. Sugachand Jain said that they received the letter from the Devasthanam on Wednesday. “We will renovate it and our ideas will be based on her dreams”.

Advocate N.L. Rajah said that the temple had complied with that part of the order which permits the Cancer Institute to renovate the residence of Dr. Muthulakshmi. They have, however, gone on appeal against the quantum of rental arrears paid by the Avvai Home. It is surprising that the temple authorities are treating the institution like a commercial enterprise, he said.

‘2,390 village panchayats turn TB-free in 2025’

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

In 2025, 2,390 village panchayats in Tamil Nadu were identified as tuberculosis-free and declared ‘TB-free panchayats’, according to a press release issued by the Health department.

Health Minister K.G. Arunraj conducted a district-wise review of the measures being undertaken to achieve TB-free Tamil Nadu on Wednesday. He also reviewed the State’s achievements and progress under the National TB Elimination Programme.

Between January and June 2026, 48,469 persons were diagnosed with TB and treatment initiated. In 2025, 93,203 persons were diagnosed with TB and were provided with the necessary treatment.

Addressing the meeting, the Minister said that the TB-free India movement requires coordinated efforts involving government and private healthcare institutions, elected representatives, NGOs and other government departments. If all government departments and all sections of society work together, the State can eliminate TB at the earliest.

Deputy directors of TB control were directed to intensify efforts in villages and urban wards that are at a higher risk of TB by using modern diagnostic tools such as chest X-rays and molecular diagnostic tests for early detection and prompt treatment.

Health Secretary Darez Ahamed was also present.

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UNAUDITED (REVIEWED) FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER ENDED 30th JUNE 2026

Sl. No.	Particulars	Quarter Ended 30.06.2026 (Unaudited)	Quarter Ended 30.06.2025 (Unaudited)	Year Ended 31.03.2026 (Audited)
1.	Total Income from Operations (net)	8,68,224	7,43,321	29,74,098
2.	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	2,57,493	94,620	4,37,349
3.	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period before tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	2,57,493	94,620	4,37,349
4.	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	65,632	60,744	2,76,786
5.	Total Comprehensive income for the period (comprising Profit/Loss) for the period (after tax) and other comprehensive income (after tax)	Refer Note 2		
6.	Paid Up Equity Share Capital	12,53,956	12,53,956	12,53,956
7.	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserves)	17,56,007	15,41,844	17,56,007
8.	Securities Premium Account	5,04,211	5,04,211	5,04,211
9.	Net Worth	27,15,348	22,22,207	24,46,221
10.	Paid up Debt Capital / Outstanding Debt	0.08	0.08	0.09
11.	Debt Equity Ratio	0.73	0.83	0.70
12.	Earning Per Share (of ₹ 10/- each) (for continuing and discontinued operations)-			
1.	Basic:	0.52	0.48	2.04
2.	Diluted:	0.52	0.48	2.04
13.	Capital Redemption Reserve	-	-	-
14.	Debtenture Redemption Reserve	-	-	-

Note : 1. The above is an extract of the detailed format of quarter ended financial results filed with the Stock Exchanges under regulation 33 and 52 of the Listing Regulations. The full format of the quarter ended financial results is available on the websites of the Stock Exchanges (www.nseindia.com and www.bseindia.com) and Bank's Website (www.uco.bank.in/investors) 2. Information relating to total comprehensive income and other comprehensive income is not furnished as Ind AS is not yet made applicable to the bank.

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TBM to bore below Phase I Nandanam metro tunnel

TBM will likely bore at this place for two weeks, at a depth of about 100 ft.; CMRL officials say the speed of the trains in Phase I will not be affected, but it may be reduced in case of any vibration

TRACK TALES
Sunitha Sekar
CHENNAI

In a couple of days, as you travel in Chennai Metro Rail trains through the tunnel of the phase I network at Nandanam, a mammoth tunnel boring machine (TBM) would be quietly crawling underneath, creating another tunnel in which commuters will travel in future.

In the 118.9-km phase II network, the corridor 4 from Poonamallee to Light House will criss-cross the phase I network's tunnel at Nandanam. As a part of this corridor has been designed as an underground network from Kodambakkam to Light House, Chennai Metro Rail has been building tunnels in short sections.

So far, two tunnel stretches – Light House to Thirumayilai and Panagal Park to Kodambakkam – have been completed. In December last year, Chennai Metro Rail commenced tunnelling from Panagal

Major project

Key details of Chennai Metro Rail's tunnel boring project from Panagal Park to Boat Club for the Phase II network



Length of tunnel from Panagal Park to Boat Club: 1.9 km

Depth of phase I tunnel in Nandanam: 16.5 metres from the ground



Depth of phase II tunnel in Nandanam: 29.8 metres from the ground



It took seven months for the TBM to tunnel from Panagal Park to Nandanam



Tunnelling from Nandanam to Boat Club is expected to be completed in December

Park yet again to bore towards Boat Club via Nandanam.

According to officials of Chennai Metro Rail Limited (CMRL), this TBM which departed from Panagal Park has now landed close to the phase I Nandanam Metro Rail station after boring through a distance of 868 metres. The machine bored through medium sand, clay and shale

stone to reach Nandanam. A process called cutter head intervention (where the cutter head discs that helps in boring through are repaired or changed) was carried out eight times for the TBM during the course of the tunnelling from Panagal Park to Nandanam.

T. Archunan, director (projects), CMRL, said the Commissioner of Railway

Safety (CRS) has given approval for the TBM to bore under the phase I Nandanam tunnel. "In a few days, the machine will bore perpendicularly under the phase I tunnel at a depth of 29.8 metres from the ground. We have placed sensors and have been monitoring the tunnel on a real time basis for the last two weeks to ensure the vibrations are within the permissible limits and there are no issues of settlements or cracks. So far, the vibrations are under control. So, we don't need to impose speed restrictions, and the train operations will continue as well," he said.

If the vibrations or settlements start to increase even by the slightest measure, then the speed of the trains which are entering the Nandanam station will be reduced for safety reasons, he added. The TBM is likely to bore under phase I tunnel at Nandanam junction for nearly two weeks. Officials said the TBM will drill through silty clay and medium sand and is likely to arrive at Boat Club in December this year.

Greater awareness needed on blood stem cell donation: experts

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A 40-year-old man from Chennai, Samnu John, who underwent an unrelated stem cell transplant for severe aplastic anaemia, met his donor for the first time on Wednesday, two years post the transplant.

At the event, Aruna Rajendran, haemato-oncologist and bone marrow transplant physician at Madras Medical College and Rajiv Gandhi Government General hospital, who headed the transplant, spoke about the need for more stem cell donor registration in the country.

"When a person is diagnosed with a life threatening condition such as severe aplastic anaemia, it leaves him or her vulnerable to infections, bleeding and with extreme exhaustion among many other complications. A stem cell transplant is the curative option for these patients but donor availability and funding for bone marrow transplantation is the biggest bottlenecks," says Dr. Rajendran.

"It took us 18 months to find the exact match for Mr. John, and now he is fully recovered and back at work. But there are several other patients who are still



DKMS Foundation India Executive Chairman Patrick Paul and haemato-oncologist Aruna Rajendran with stem cell donor Paritosh and patient Samnu John at a press conference in the city on Wednesday. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

struggling to find a suitable match," she said, adding that donor availability and willingness to donate are two different things.

Dr. Rajendran also noted that awareness should extend beyond individuals to families so they are more supportive when their children choose to register themselves as stem cell donors.

Mr. John, recalling the ordeals he went through, said he had to quit his job because of severe symptoms. "Survival itself was difficult both before and after diagnosis. My family members were not a match for donor and I was so tired of waiting for one. But we finally managed to find the right match through DKMS Foundation," he said.

Patrick Paul, Executive Chairman, DKMS Foundation India, spoke about the need for more people to register as stem cell donors.

Financial support

He also noted that the foundation has provided financial support too for some patients without government health insurance.

Mr. John's donor, a 25-year-old Paritosh from Uttar Pradesh, said myths around stem cell donation should be debunked. "It is not Marvel or DC but a superhero within all of us. We have to step forward and help people suffering from these rare blood disorders in whatever way we can," he says.

Police arrest three persons for clashing with college students

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Government Railway Police arrested three youth for indulging in a clash involving students of Pachaiyappa's College and Nandanam Government Arts College at the Guindy Railway Station here on Tuesday. One of the arrested was a former student of Pachaiyappa's College.

Three knives, six stones, and 10 broken bottles used in the violence were seized. According to the police, the two groups of students hurled stones, knives, and broken bottles at each other.

The Mambalam Railway Police registered a case and arrested Kanagavel, 20, of Pallavaram, who discontinued his studies at Pachaiyappa's College; Vishwa Guru, 19, of Padappai in Kancheepuram, a third-year student of Pachaiyappa's College; and Raja, 19, of Arumbakkam, a student of Nandanam Government Arts College.

The police said they would continue the investigation to identify and apprehend other college students involved in the clash.



Dignitaries at the launch of the Kauvery 3X Chennai, an integrated robotic surgery programme, on Wednesday. M. SRINATH

City hospital launches integrated robotic surgery programme

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Kauvery Hospital has launched Kauvery 3X Chennai, an integrated robotic surgery programme that brings together robotic surgical services across its three hospitals in the city under a common framework of multidisciplinary care and standardised clinical protocols.

The programme will use the fourth-generation da Vinci robotic surgical system and will cover multiple specialties, including gastrointestinal surgery, surgical oncology, urology, gynaecology, and kidney transplantation.

The programme will support robotic-assisted procedures for gastrointestinal and colorectal cancers, gynaecological and breast cancers, urological cancers, hysterectomy, endometriosis, fibroid surgery, ovarian procedures, prostate and kid-

ney surgeries, bladder and reconstructive urological procedures, thyroidectomy, hernia repair, gallbladder surgery, colorectal surgery, and upper gastrointestinal procedures.

The hospital said one of the programme's focus areas would be robotic kidney transplantation, alongside other minimally invasive procedures for complex surgical conditions.

Aravindan Selvaraj, co-founder and executive director, Kauvery Group of Hospitals, said the initiative aimed to provide patients with access to robotic surgery across multiple specialties at the group's Chennai hospitals while maintaining uniform standards of care. He added that the programme reflected the hospital's investment in surgical innovation and multidisciplinary care, with the goal of improving patient outcomes and expanding access to advanced surgical treatment.

Ex-AIADMK MLA's son killed in road accident

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Ulagu Athipathi, 21, son of former AIADMK MLA P. Periyapulan, was killed after his motorcycle crashed into an earthmover on Sardar Patel Road in Guindy on Wednesday. The victim hailed from Melur taluk in Madurai.

The police said Athipathi was

thrown off his two-wheeler after his vehicle collided with the earthmover near the Highways Department office around 7.30 a.m. He was then run over by the heavy vehicle.

On receiving information, personnel from the Traffic Investigation Wing, Mylapore, rushed to the scene and sent the body for a post-mortem examination.

Truck owners' association alleges traffic police harass drivers

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu Lorry Owners and Suppliers Association in a press meet organised in the city on Wednesday highlighted a number of issues affecting the operation of trucks.

They said that the traffic police personnel threaten to file drunk driving cases against truck drivers without any valid reason.

A. Ganesh Bengera, president of the association, said that in the past three months, the city traffic police personnel

have been harassing truck drivers regularly by detaining the trucks for more than four hours to file drunk driving cases against the drivers.

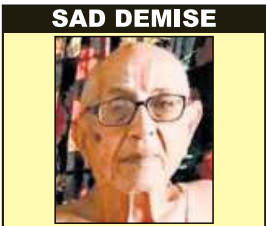
But when the truck owner or the driver ask for a proper case to be filed, they refuse to do so, holding the vehicles for

days, leading to delayed deliveries, he added. The association members also pointed out that if truck drivers are involved in any accident, the police officials, without proper investigation, file the First Information Report (FIR) against the drivers, and in

some cases harass the drivers, demanding money. This has resulted in drivers not willing to take up the job of driving trucks. The association wanted the Additional Commissioner of Police (Traffic) to hold a meeting with truck owners to resolve the issue at the earliest.

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH



Sri. K.R. RAMASESHAN
(Retd. Process Superintendent, THE HINDU) attained **Acharyan Thiruvadi** on 21.07.26 at his residence.

Deeply mourned by Son, K.R. Anand, Dil: Usha Anand Daughters: Sasi Lakshmiopathy, Kumudha Muralidharan, Grandchildren and Great Grandchildren.

DEATH



Thiru T.T. THULASIRAM (89 Yrs)
Passed Away: 22nd July 2026
Cremation: 12:00 Noon, 23rd July at Kannamapet Crematorium

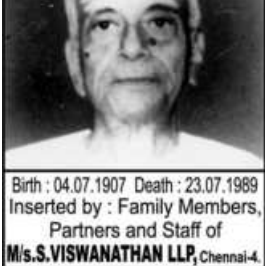
Deeply mourned and fondly remembered by his family and friends
Ph: 9940052565

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES



Sri P.K. VENKATADRI M.A.
Retd. A.O. A.G.'s Office
Simple, Pious and a noble soul.
Our Salutations to You.
Inserted by **Family Members.**
Ph: 9841071050

IN FOND MEMORY OF Sri S.VISWANATHAN
On the Occasion of the Thirty Seventh Anniversary



Mr P.K Padmanabhan
Date of Death: 21st July, 2026
Phone - 9500086000

IN MEMORY OF YOUR LOVED ONES

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DEATH



Mr. Koshy Zachariah (67 yrs)
Retd. Executive Director Finance, MRF Ltd, Chennai
Passed away at his residence on 19.07.2026
Funeral on 24.07.2026. Service & Viewing: At **Christ Church**, # 55-56, Mount Road, Opp GPO, Chennai-02 (Under the auspices of Bethesda Bible Chapel). Burial: At 12.30PM, Kilpauk Cemetery, Chennai - 102.

Fondly remembered by Family & Friends.
Wife: Late Mrs. Daisy Zachariah
Children: Viju K Zachariah, Vinu Tony Thompson & Dr. Tony Thompson Chandy.

Grandchildren: David Zachariah, Michael Thomson, Sharon Thompson.

22nd ANNIVERSARY



Smt. SUSILA SUBRAMANIAM
W/o. Late K.P. Subramaniam
07-05-1928 - 23-07-2004

Fondly Remembered by **K.S. MOHAN, UMA MURALI SHWETHA, SHRADHA & APSARA**

DEATH

OBITUARY



Mr. K.J. Joseph

Chairman Emeritus of Thejo Engineering Ltd.

"I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race, I have kept the faith."
- 2 Timothy 4:7

A visionary leader, distinguished industrialist and a man of deep faith & unwavering values, Mr. Joseph, Founder Chairman, dedicated his life to building an institution founded on excellence, integrity, innovation and care for people. Through his inspiring leadership and unwavering commitment to ethical business practices, he played a pivotal role in shaping Thejo Engineering Ltd into a globally respected engineering enterprise. He was actively involved in social activities amongst which leadership development of youth is worth mentioning.

Beyond his professional achievements, he was a devoted family man whose humility, compassion, wisdom and generosity touched the lives of countless people. His legacy will continue to inspire generations, and his values will remain deeply embedded in the organization he nurtured and the lives he enriched. He will be deeply missed and fondly remembered by his family, friends, colleagues, employees, business associates and all whose lives were privileged to be touched by his guidance and kindness.

FUNERAL SERVICE

Date : **Friday, 24 July 2026 Time : 8:30 a.m. - 10:30 a.m.**

Venue : **Santhome Cathedral Basilica, Mylapore, Chennai. Ph : 9444034087**

Cremation : **Besant Nagar Crematorium 11:30 a.m.**

May the Lord grant him eternal rest and comfort all who mourn his passing.

The bereaved family



THEJO ENGINEERING LTD.

INBRIEF



Officials directed to expedite civic works in Ambattur Zone

Greater Chennai Corporation Central Regional Deputy Commissioner H.R. Kaushik on Wednesday inspected various development projects under way in Ambattur Zone, and directed officials to expedite their completion. According to a press release, the inspection covered stormwater drain and canal improvement and desilting works, the TVS canal, Korattur surplus canal, Karuppan Kulam, works, a cattle shelter, a dog birth control centre, school and additional classroom construction, an Amma Unavagam, a conservancy workers' rest room, sports facilities, and beautification works.



GCC official inspects civic works in Tiruvottiyur Zone

Greater Chennai Corporation North Regional Deputy Commissioner Sweta Suman on Wednesday inspected a silt-filtering tank, an under construction Urban Primary Health Centre, an Amma Unavagam, sewage pumping stations, canals, an animal birth control centre, and a cattle shelter in Tiruvottiyur Zone. According to a press release, she directed officials to remove stagnant rainwater and silt, maintain food quality and hygiene at the Amma Unavagam, ensure proper upkeep of pumping station equipment and maintain the cattle shelter.

City may see thunderstorms today; feeble trough to bring rainfall over parts of State

RMC says searing heat is likely to persist in interior parts of Tamil Nadu due to weak Southwest monsoon; rain to increase over north Tamil Nadu and Western Ghats regions during the weekend

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A feeble trough extending along Tamil Nadu coast is likely to bring a brief break from dry weather, with scattered rainfall expected over parts of the State till July 28.

Rainfall is likely to become more significant during the weekend as favourable weather conditions develop.

Coastal districts may experience near-normal day temperatures owing to the moderating influence of sea breeze circulation. Chennai may have chances of thunderstorms during evening/night hours, and the maximum temperature may remain near normal of 36-37 degrees Celsius on Thursday.

Searing heat

However, the Regional Meteorological Centre (RMC) has noted that temperature levels would continue to climb above average in isolated pockets of interior Tamil Nadu. Searing heat is likely to persist in interior parts like Madurai and Karur, despite the wet spell likely in parts of the State.

On Wednesday too, Madurai Airport topped the charts with the State's highest maximum temper-



Spell of relief: The Regional Meteorological Centre has predicted that light to moderate rainfall would occur at isolated places of the State till Friday. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

ature of 41.5 degrees Celsius. It was followed by Madurai city with 40.4 degrees Celsius. Various other weather stations, including Tiruttani, Tiruchi and Velore too recorded above-normal maximum temperatures.

Nungambakkam and Meenambakkam in Chennai recorded 38.2 degrees Celsius and 38.4 degrees Celsius respectively, which is nearly three degrees Celsius above average.

A few areas like Poona-mallee, Coonoor and Valparai recorded mild rainfall till 6 p.m. on Wednesday.

RMC officials said the conditions are favourable

for thunderstorm activity, with gusty winds reaching speeds of 40-50 kmph in isolated places of Tamil Nadu and Pudukcherry. However, the Southwest monsoon is in a weak phase over the southern peninsular region.

The RMC has predicted light to moderate rainfall at isolated places of the State till Friday, and there may be an increase in rainfall intensity particularly over parts of north Tamil Nadu and Western Ghats region on Saturday and Sunday.

While the Western Ghats region is expected to receive moderate rainfall in isolated pockets, mild rainfall may continue in

other parts of the State till July 28. V.R. Durai, Head, Regional Weather Forecasting Centre, RMC, said whenever monsoon performs poorly in Kerala, interior parts of the State sizzle with high temperatures. With monsoon remaining weak in the State, chances for widespread rainfall are limited for the next few days.

He pointed out that reduced daytime cloud cover, dry lower-level atmospheric conditions and delayed development of thunderstorm activity may enhance daytime heating in interior parts. However, heatwave conditions are not expected.

High Court dismisses Senthilbalaji's plea to prevent police from 'harassing' him, his brother in any case

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

The Madras High Court on Wednesday dismissed two petitions, filed by former DMK Minister V. Senthilbalaji and his brother R.V. Ashok Kumar, to restrain Directorate of Vigilance and Anti Corruption (DVAC), Greater Chennai Police and Karur police from "harassing" them "in the guise of search, inquiry or investigation" in any pending or proposed criminal case.

Justice G.K. Ilanthirayan said, no such direction could be issued since the petitioners had already obtained anticipatory bail in the pending cases and it would be premature to issue such a direction by anticipating the registration of criminal cases against them in the future. The pleas were rejected following stiff opposition by State Public Prosecutor (SPP) R. John Sathyan.

The SPP told the court that though the petitioners had obtained anticipatory bail in some of the pending cases, they were yet to surrender before the jurisdictional magistrate for the purpose of executing bonds and furnishing sureties. He said, the petitioners could not obtain a blanket order against their arrest in any case by seeking a direction to the police

to not harass them.

In his petition, Mr. Senthilbalaji had said, even after the High Court had granted anticipatory bail to him as well as his brother in a case related to alleged bribe of ₹35 crore having been offered to Uthangarai TVK MLA N. Elaiyaraja to act against the interests of his party, "the search operation and attempts to keep the petitioner and his family under continuous pressure have not ceased."

The plea went on to read: "The petitioner reliably understands that there is an instruction from the political top that, one way or another, the petitioner and his brother must be implicated in some other case and mandated for 'settling scores.' The petitioner submits that the continued search operation, after the grant of anticipatory bail, is not for any bonafide investigative purpose, but is intended to create an atmosphere for arrest in one case or another and to humiliate the petitioner politically."

He also alleged that the ruling dispensation had developed an animosity against him and his brother ever since the death of 41 people due to a stampede that occurred during Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay's election campaign in Karur on September 27, 2026.

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CORRIGENDUM NO. 01 AGAINST TENDER NOTICE NO. M-TSK-2026-15

Corrigendum no. 01 against Tender Notice No. M-TSK-2026-15, Date: 10-07-2026 has been issued. Bidders are requested to visit website www.ireps.gov.in for details.

Sr. DME/Tinsukia NORTHEAST FRONTIER RAILWAY Serving Customers With A Smile

BHAKRA BEAS MANAGEMENT BOARD

(A Statutory Body under the Ministry of Power, Government of India)

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

BBMB invites online tender (Tender ID-2026_BBMB_284424_1, dated 22.07.2026) for Appointment of an IRDAI-Registered Direct/Composite Insurance Broker for Providing Insurance Broking and Risk Management Consultancy Services to BBMB for a Period of Two (02) Years from the Date of Award of the Brokerage Assignment. For detailed tender, please visit CPP portal and BBMB website www.bbmb.gov.in

303-PR-BD, Sectt.-5 For your Better Tomorrow Save Energy Today

New Tirupur Area Development Corporation Limited (NTADCL)

"Polyhose Towers" 1st Floor, No.86, Mount Road, Guindy, Chennai - 600 032

New Tirupur Area Development Corporation Limited (NTADCL), the pioneering Special Purpose Vehicle (SPV) that implemented India's first private sector-led integrated water supply and sanitation project, has played a transformational role in the development of the Tirupur, Erode and including some areas, adjacent Coimbatore region. Over the years, NTADCL has established significant benchmarks in the water infrastructure sector and continues to expand its footprint with a forward-looking growth and sustainability vision.

To strengthen its operational leadership and support its future growth initiatives, NTADCL invites applications from qualified, result-oriented, and self-motivated professionals for the position of:

MANAGER - OPERATIONS Location - Tirupur

Qualification: Bachelor's Degree (B.E./B.Tech.) in Civil Engineering from a recognized university

Experience: Minimum 7 to 10 years of relevant experience in water & wastewater operations, project execution, and maintenance activities, preferably in the infrastructure Sector/ Companies.

CTC: ₹ 12 lakhs Per Annum

For details of the job Description pls visit our website: www.ntadcl.com

Interested candidates may email their detailed resume to contactus@ntadcl.com on or before 06.08.2026 by 5:30 PM.

DIPR/ 645 /DISPLAY/2026

THE HINDU

Air Surcharge as applicable:

New Delhi - Rs. 15/-; Port Blair - Rs. 20/-

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-TENDER NOTICE

OPEN E-TENDER NOTICE NO.- T-SEE-GSU-ABSS-2026-27-01.

CAO/CONRSP/MHX for and on behalf of the President of India invites Open E-Tenders for the following works. The last date of online E-tendering is 18.08.2026 up to 15:00 hrs. All information and tender documents related to E-tender is available on website-www.ireps.gov.in.

1. Name of works : Balance work of - 1) HLP extension- raising & surfacing, approach road around the pond, boundary wall, circulating and parking area & other misc. works at Ram Dayalu Nagar. 2) PF surfacing, boundary wall, Ramp for FOB, approach road, circulating & parking area & other misc. works at Dalsingh Sarai. 3) Boundary wall, widening of approach road, toe wall, 6m wide FOB with ramp, circulating & parking area & other misc. works at Karhagola Road. 4) PF Surfacing, approach road, boundary wall, ramp for FOB, circulating and parking area & other misc. works at Mansi. 5) HLP extension-raising & surfacing, boundary wall, PF shed, coping block, circulating and parking area, passenger amenities & other misc. works at Mahesh Khunt. 6) Boundary wall, passenger amenities, circulating & parking area, & other misc. works at Lakshminia. 7) Boundary wall, ramp for FOB, extension of circulating and parking area & other misc. works at Bhagwanpur. 8) PF Surfacing, PF shed & other misc. works at Sonpur. 9) PF raising & surfacing, Ramp for FOB, approach road, boundary wall, utility shifting and extension of circulating area and parking area & other misc. works at Dighwara. 10) VIP lounge, pathway, drain, staff toilet, 6m wide new FOB and ramp for existing FOB & other misc. works at Shahpur Patoree. 11) PF Surfacing, boundary wall, ramp for FOB, circulating & parking area & other misc. works at Khagaria. Provision of 1) 2nd entry building, Circulating area, drain, parking area, boundary wall, PF surfacing, & other misc. balance works of 1st entry at Hajipur. 2) 2nd entry building. Shifting of AEN HQ & AEN Line office, shifting of IOW office & store, circulating & parking area, drain & other misc. works at Sonpur. 3) 2nd entry building, Parking area, drain, approach road, boundary wall, PF surfacing, ramp for FOB & other misc. works at Naugachia. 4) Provision of Building, PF surfacing, Ramp for FOB, approach road, boundary wall and circulating area, parking area & other misc. works at Sahabpur Kamal. 2. Advertised Value (In Rs.): ₹1775306033.08. 3. Earnest Money (In Rs.): ₹35506100.00

The above tender notice is available on website www.ireps.gov.in. RIGHT OF RAILWAY TO DEAL WITH TENDER: Railway Administration reserves the right to postpone/modify or to cancel any one or all the tenders without assigning any reason.

Dy. Chief Project Manager/ Gati Shakti/ECR/Sonpur PR/0592/SEE/GS/T/26-27/88

EDUCATION HUB

A Business Initiative

STAR Summit's Student Research

The valedictory function of the 13th Saveetha Transdisciplinary Annual Research Summit (STAR Summit 2026) was held at Saveetha Dental College. Dr. Umesh Shaligram, Executive Director, R&D, Serum Institute of India, was the Chief Guest and presented trophies to the winners in the presence of Dr. N.M. Veeraiyan, Chancellor, and Dr. Deepak Nallaswamy, Pro-Chancellor, SIMATS. The five-day summit provided a platform for dental students to showcase research across clinical dentistry, genetics, digital dentistry and emerging disciplines. It featured 2,750 research projects, over 1,000 evaluations and 350 awards. Eminent guests included Dr. S.A. Rizwan, Dr. S.P. Subramanian, Dr. Prashanthi Reddy and Dr. Vinod Krishnan.

M.O.P Launches FinTax Café

M.O.P. Vaishnav College for Women's B.Com Finance and Taxation Programme launched FinTax Café on July 21, creating a relaxed space for students to engage with finance and taxation experts over coffee and snacks. The inaugural session featured about 20 students in conversation with Ms. Lokeshwarri S K, Senior Associate Editor and Head of the Data vertical at The Hindu BusinessLine, discussing savings, investments, influencers, gold, settlements and AI. Principal Dr. Archana Prasad prefaced the session by setting the context. "At M.O.P., we have always believed in taking learning outside the classroom," she said, "but taking it into the canteen is something different."

25 Years of Patrician College

Patrician College of Arts and Science, Adyar, Chennai, will conclude its year-long Silver Jubilee celebrations with a Closing Ceremony on August 1, 2026. Inspired by Bishop Daniel Delany, who founded the Congregation of the Brothers of St. Patrick in Ireland in 1808, the College has empowered thousands through education rooted in faith, compassion, integrity, excellence and service. Its multidisciplinary programmes, research, scholarships and community initiatives reflect 25 years of transforming lives through education and values.

HGI Signs MoU with USM

Hindustan Group of Institutions (HGI), India, has recently signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with the University of Southern Mindanao (USM), Philippines, in the presence of Dr. Jonald Lozarito Pimentel, SUC President IV, and Prof. Dr. Marcos Fernandez Monderlin, Director, International Affairs, from the University of Southern Mindanao. HGI and USM will explore collaboration in AI, Drone Technology, Electric Mobility, Data Science, Smart Agriculture, and sustainable development, working together on joint research projects, entrepreneurship activities, and academic engagements, addressing evolving global challenges. Dr. Anand Jacob Verghese, Chairman, HGI, said: "This partnership is more than a formal agreement; it reflects our shared vision of advancing academic excellence through global collaboration."

REC's World Record at AI NEXUS

Rajalakshmi Engineering College (REC), Chennai, made history by establishing a World Record at its flagship AI NEXUS 2026 - An AI Tech Summit. During the "Agentic AI Botathon 1000," 1,000 students developed 1,000 fully functional Agentic AI Bots in just two hours, marking one of the largest hands-on AI initiatives by an academic institution. The summit was inaugurated by Dr. Kumar R (Hons), Minister for AI, Information Technology & Digital Services, Government of TN, who addressed the gathering alongside Dr. (Mrs.) Thangam Meganathan, Chairperson of RGI, and Dr. S. N. Murugesan, Principal. The official World Record Citation was presented to Dr. Murugesan in the presence of Mr. Christopher Taylor Craft, Records Manager, World Record Union.

Guru Nanak College's Bastille Day

Guru Nanak College (Autonomous) celebrated Bastille Day 2026, welcoming Mr. Hugues Boiteau, Scientific and Academic Attaché for South India at the Consulate General of France in Pudukcherry - Institut Français India, as Chief Guest. Held under the theme "Égalité to Ekta"/"From Equality to Unity"—the programme featured performances created in collaboration with the Department of Visual Arts and GTech. Intercollegiate Oratorical and Digital Poster-Making competitions were also organised.

Govt. of Bihar

State Investment Promotion Board Cell
Department of Industries
Government of Bihar, Patna

Tender Notice No:-SIPB/2172

Online e-tender are invited by the Director of Industries, Department of Industries, Govt. of Bihar, Patna for Selection of a System Integrator for Design, Development, implementation and maintenance of unified single window system web portal and mobile application of Invest Bihar Portal.

S.N	Tender Schedule/Program	
1	Name of the customer and address from whose website the RFP documents can be obtained	Director Industries, Department of Industries, 2 nd floor, Vikas Bhawan, Patna, Bihar-800001, Telephone No: 0612-2235812 Email Id: dir.ind-bih@nic.in 22/07/2026
2	Publishing of RFP	
3	Last date for submission of queries for clarifications	31/07/2026 at 12.00 P.M
4	Date of pre-bid conference (virtual)	03/08/2026 at 3.00 P.M
5	Release of response to clarifications	06/08/2026
6	Bid validity period	180 days from the last date (deadline) for submission of proposals.
	Last date (deadline) for submission of bids	11/08/2026 at 6.00 P.M
6	Opening of Technical Bids	12/08/2026 PM, Department of Industries, 2 nd floor, Vikas Bhawan, Patna, Bihar-800001
7	Technical Presentation by the Bidders	19/08/2026
	Place, Time and Date of opening of Financial proposals received in response to the RFP notice	24/08/2026
9	Award of Contract	28/08/2026
	Tender Fees	INR 10,000/- Ten Thousand Only
10	Tender Processing fee	As Per Eproc2
11	EMD	INR 20,00,000/- Twenty Lakh Only

Note:

- Director Industries, Department of Industries, Patna, Bihar reserves the right to reject or cancel the tender or any part thereof without assigning any reasons.
- The tender document can be obtained from the website of Department of Industries, Government of Bihar
- For any queries regarding tender please contact: 0612-2235812 or 18003456214 and email: dir.ind-bih@nic.in or sipb.care@bihar.gov.in

Toll Free Number: 1800 572 6571, Email Id: eproc2support@bihar.gov.in
During 08:00 AM to 07:00 PM (All days in week except state holidays)

eProc 2.0 Help Desk Address:

RJ Complex, 2nd Floor, Opposite Vidyapeeth Institute, Khajpura, Ashiana Road, P.S. - Shastri Nagar, Patna 800 014, Bihar

For further details please visit : www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar

PR. No. 008385 (Industry) 2026-27

Department of Industries

नशामुक्त हो जाए बिहार, सुरक्षित रहे घर परिवार।

INBRIEF



Six-year-old dies as tree falls on school bus in Karnataka

A six-year-old girl died, and two other children were injured when a tree fell on a school bus in Barimaru village in Dakshina Kannada region of Karnataka on Wednesday. According to the police, the incident occurred when the bus was taking the students home. The bus had stopped near a building because of heavy rain when a large portion of a tree fell on the bus. The three injured students were taken to a nearby hospital, where one died of injuries, the police added.

New team begins probe into death of Kerala BDS student

The Crime Branch of the Kerala Police will re-arrest M.K. Ram, the first accused in the death of first-year BDS student Nithin Raj of the Kannur Dental College, Anjarakandy, Superintendent of Police M. Mohanachandran said on Wednesday. Dr. Ram is a former Head of the Dental Anatomy Department at the college. A fresh Crime Branch team has commenced its probe. The team will speak to Nithin's family members and also look at the alleged role of loan app operators in the case.

Non-hallmarked gold jewellery worth around ₹10 crore seized

The Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS) seized approximately 7.875 kg of non-hallmarked gold jewellery worth around ₹10 crore during a raid on a jewellery shop in Warangal district for allegedly violating the mandatory hallmarking provisions under the BIS Act, 2016. The search and seizure operation was carried out by officials of the BIS Hyderabad Branch Office. The agency said further action has been initiated against the establishment.

Over 47 lakh voters flagged for possible deletion in SIR

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

More than 47 lakh voters, accounting for 8.48% of Karnataka's electorate, have been flagged under various categories that could result in the possible deletion of their names from the electoral rolls during the SIR exercise, according to data released by V. Anbu Kumar, the Chief Electoral Officer, Karnataka, on Wednesday. Mr. Kumar said that the figure does not represent the number of voters who would be deleted from the electoral roll. They will undergo further verification before any decision on deletion is taken, he said.

LDF agreed to pick non-Muslim members for Waqf Board: CM

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The previous CPI(M)-led LDF government had agreed to appoint two non-Muslim members to the Kerala Waqf Board but at a later stage, Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan has said. The assurance was part of the government order on the board formation issued at the time, he added. At a post-Cabinet press briefing, he accused Leader of the Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan of engaging in communal propaganda to turn the Muslim community against the UDF government. "It is on record. Their [LDF] government had gi-

Kerala doctors save tribal woman, baby after uterine rupture

Abdul Latheef Naha
MALAPPURAM

A swift, coordinated response by doctors at Government District Hospital, Nilambur, in Kerala saved the lives of a 25-year-old tribal woman and her newborn after a rare uterine rupture left the baby lying inside the mother's abdominal cavity. The woman from Cheerakkuzhi tribal hamlet near Chugathara was brought to the hospital around 10.40 a.m. on Monday with severe abdominal pain. By that time, her amniotic sac had ruptured, and thick meconium-stained fluid was draining.

She received no antenatal care and had been advised against another pregnancy

She had received no antenatal care. There had been no scans or blood tests. "It was difficult even to grasp the baby. We somehow delivered the child and immediately handed the newborn to the paediatrician," senior gynaecologist Laxmy Rajmohan said. The woman had two caesarean deliveries before and had been advised against another pregnancy due to uterine issues.

Maintain status quo on water release, says Cauvery body

CWMA directs Tamil Nadu and Karnataka to use present storage only for drinking purposes; it takes note of poor rainfall in basin, says Karnataka released only 0.54 tmcft of water in July so far

B.S. Satish Kumar
BENGALURU

Taking a serious note of poor rainfall in the Cauvery basin, the Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA), which met in Delhi on Wednesday, has directed both Karnataka and Tamil Nadu to strictly confine use of their storage to drinking water purposes. The CWMA, which is the apex body that monitors implementation of Cauvery water release to lower riparian States as per the Supreme Court's verdict, directed both the States to maintain status quo with respect to water release and utilisation. According to sources,



Trying times: The water level in the KRS dam across the Cauvery in Karnataka is fast depleting. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

the CWMA referred to the IMD forecast that indicates further tough time in terms of rainfall in the coming days, and observed that it is going to be a distress year for the Cauvery basin. The present storage in

reservoirs of the Cauvery basin in both Karnataka and Tamil Nadu could only take care of their drinking water requirements, the authority reportedly observed. Warning both the States

against using the water storage for other purposes including irrigation, the authority expressed confidence that it would be possible to prevent any drinking water shortage if the storage in reservoirs is judiciously used, sources said. At the meeting, it was also noted that Karnataka had released only 2.5 tmcft of water in June and 0.54 tmcft during July so far to Tamil Nadu, which is lower than that prescribed.

Review on July 28 The situation will be reviewed on July 28 by the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee, which assists the CWMA in monitoring the storage, releases and other issues.

Anti-ragging law gets Kerala Cabinet nod

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Kerala Cabinet on Wednesday gave its nod for framing an anti-ragging law and launching an app in memory of veterinary sciences student J.S. Sidharthan, whose death in 2024, allegedly following brutal ragging, had triggered a public outcry. Briefing presspersons, Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan said the app could be

used to tip off authorities about ragging incidents. Both proposals were part of the Revised Budget for 2026-27 presented by the UDF government on June 19. In his Budget speech, Mr. Satheesan had announced that the 'Sidharthan Student Distress App' would be introduced, and the 'Sidharthan Anti-Ragging and Student Welfare Act' would be enacted to prevent ragging incidents.

Airline crew member sexually assaulted

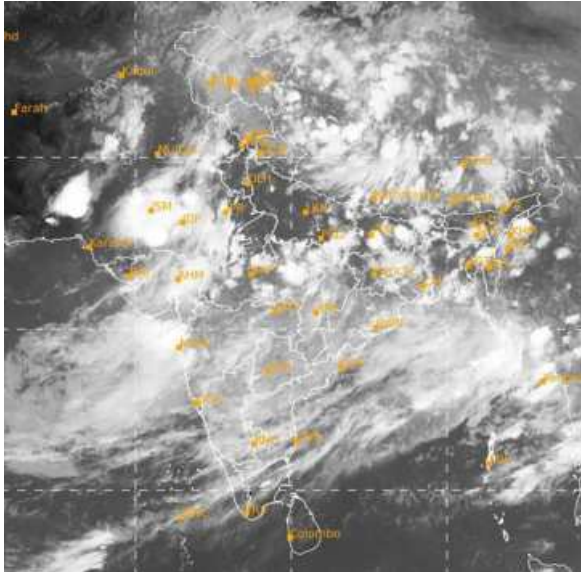
The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

A 23-year-old cab driver was arrested for sexually assaulting an IndiGo airline cabin crew member while she was travelling to the Rajiv Gandhi International Airport in Hyderabad to report for duty. The accused, identified as Prashant Kumar, was employed as a driver with the airline's cab service for staff. According to the police,

the incident occurred around 2 p.m. on July 20. The driver reportedly diverted the vehicle to a secluded area near an under-construction school on the outskirts of Shamshabad, where he sexually assaulted the woman. Hearing the woman's screams, workers at the nearby construction site rushed to her aid. Based on her complaint, the police registered a case and arrested the accused on Tuesday.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 18.15 HRS)			
Forecast for Thursday: Heavy/very heavy rainfall likely at isolated places over Gujarat, Rajasthan, Jammu & Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Assam, Meghalaya, Nagaland, Mizoram, Tripura, West Bengal, Jharkhand, Odisha, Telangana, Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Konkan & Goa, Karnataka, Kerala and Mahe			
CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala		18.2	 32.4
Ahmedabad		3.9	 32.2
Aizawl		8	 32.2
Bengaluru			27.2
Bhopal		52.6	 26.0
Bhubaneswar		37.5	 32.4
Chandigarh		7.7	 34.2
Chennai			38.4
Coimbatore			32.2
Dehradun		10.8	 32.0
Gangtok		12.2	 21.6
Goa		16.2	 31.7
Guwahati		4.6	 32.4
Hubballi			25.0
Hyderabad		4.8	 28.2
Imphal		0.2	 30.3
Jaipur		6.3	 32.7
Kochi			30.6
Kohima			26.0
Kolkata		4.8	 30.6
Kozhikode			30
Kurnool		3.2	 30.8
Lucknow		7	 33.3
Madurai			41.5
Mangaluru		39	 26.2
Mumbai			48.4
Mysuru			31.0
New Delhi			12
Patna		1	 33.3
Port Blair			6.4
Prayagraj		7.2	 33.4
Puducherry			37.4
Pune			49.8
Raipur			67
Ranchi			18
Shillong			20
Shimla			66.5
Srinagar			8.5
Thiruvananthapuram			3
Tiruchirappalli			
Vijayawada			
Visakhapatnam			0.8

Pollutants in the air you are breathing				Yesterday
CITY	SO ₂	PM ₁₀	PM _{2.5}	CODE
Ahmedabad		37	 59	 48
Bengaluru		11	 31	 57
Chennai			5	 12
Delhi			8	 27
Hyderabad			14	 13
Kolkata			14	 21
Lucknow			34	 12
Mumbai			9	 84
Pune			19	 75
Visakhapatnam			24	 59

Air Quality Code: Poor Moderate Good (Readings indicate average AQI)

SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.

PM₁₀: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease.

PM_{2.5} & PM₁₀: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease.

Karnataka Cabinet expansion delayed again

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The expansion of the Karnataka Cabinet has been postponed for the second time in less than two weeks. The delay came as the party's top leadership remained preoccupied with NEET protests.

SOUTH EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY
E-TENDER NOTICE

S.N. (1) E-Tender No. CPM-ENGGSU-BSP-05-26-27, Date: 17.07.2026

Work: "Development of Maintenance Facilities for Amrit Bharat Trains at Coaching Depot/Bilaspur including Construction of Heavy Repair Bay and Service-cum-store Building for Amrit/Vande Bharat Trains Maintenance at Bilaspur in Engineering Procurement, Construction (EPC) mode".

Tender Value (In Rs.): 96,18,00,000.00/- EMD (In Rs.): 1,92,36,000.00/- Completion Period: 12 Months, Start date of Submission of Tender: From 07.10.2026, Last date of Submission of Tender: Upto 15:00 hrs. on 21.10.2026.

The complete information of above e-Tender Notice is available over websites <https://www.reps.gov.in>. Bids other than e-bids shall not be accepted against above Tenders.

Dy. Chief Engg./GSU
CPR/10/302 S.E.C. Railway, Bilaspur

South East Central Railway @secrail

CANTONMENT BOARD
St. Thomas Mount cum Pallavaram
Ministry of Defence, Government of India
Chennai-600 016.

INVITING EXPRESSION OF INTERESTS (EOI)

Expression of Interests (EOIs) are invited for conducting Energy Audit of St.Thomas Mount cum Pallavaram Cantonment. The details of Eligibility criteria, Guidelines for submission of EOIs and other Terms and Conditions are available on the Cantonment Board Office website: <https://stm.cantt.gov.in>

The last date for receipt of the application is within 07 days from the date of advertisement. Sd/-
(BHUPATI ROHIT, I.D.E.S)
Chief Executive Officer
St. Thomas Mount cum Pallavaram Cantonment Board

No.STM/Works/1/1511
Dated: 22-07-2026.

KARNATAKA INDUSTRIAL AREAS DEVELOPMENT BOARD
(A Government of Karnataka Undertaking)
No.2, 2/1 and 2/3, Kalidasa Marg, 1st Main Road, Gandhinagar
Bengaluru-560 009, Phone No. 080-22265383
website : www.kiadb.in e-Mail: cdocet@kiadb.in
No.IADB/ENG/PMC/EP/TND-EP-06/2254 /2026-27 Date: 22.07.2026

SHORT-TERM NOTICE INVITING TENDER FOR PROVIDING PROJECT MANAGEMENT CONSULTANCY SERVICES (Through KPP Portal Only)

KIADB is inviting tender under Quality and Cost Based Selection (QCBS) as per the Karnataka Transparency in Public Procurement Act 1999 and Rules 2000 through electronic procurement from eligible Consulting Firms under two cover system for the following works: Name of the work: (1) Project Management Consultancy Services for the work of Formation of 15m Wide Road, 18m Wide Road, 24m Wide Road, 30m Wide Road & 45m Wide Road, Construction of RCC Side Drain, Construction of Spur Culvert & Construction of Box Culvert at Dobaspet 5th Phase Industrial Area, Nelamangala Taluk, Bengaluru Rural District. (2) Project Management Consultancy Services for the work of Formation of Industrial Layout, Including Construction of Flexible Pavement Roads, RCC Side Drains, RCC Chambers, RCC Storm Water Drains, RCC Cross Drainages, Laying of HDPE Pipes for Water Supply Works etc., at proposed Chintamani Industrial Area, Phase-I, Chikkaballapura District.

Last Date and Time for Receipt of Tenders: 10.08.2026 up to 4:00 pm Applicants may download bidding documents from the Karnataka Public Procurement portal <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in> Sd/- Engineer-In-Chief, K.I.A.D.B

JAN BHAVAN, LUCKNOW.

NOTICE INVITING APPLICATIONS FOR APPOINTMENT OF VICE CHANCELLOR FOR BHATKHANDE SANSKRITI VISHWAVIDYALAYA, LUCKNOW (U.P.)

Advt. No. E-4919 /2026 Dated : July 22, 2026

Application were invited Online by the Advertisement No. E-7190 /2025, dated October 06, 2025, however any of the applicant has not be found suitable for appointment as Vice Chancellor.

It is proposed to appoint the Vice-Chancellor for Bhatkhande Sanskriti Vishwavidyalaya, Lucknow (U.P.), established under the Bhatkhande Sanskriti Vishwavidyalaya Act, 2022 by the Chancellor, out of a panel to be recommended by a Committee appointed in terms of Section- 11(1) of the said Act.

The Vice-Chancellor shall hold office for a term of 03 years from the date on which he/she enters upon his/her office or till he/she attains the age of 68 years whichever is earlier. Only such person shall be eligible for appointment to the office of Vice Chancellor who has not attained the age of 65 years.

As the Vice Chancellor is the Principal Executive and Academic Officer of the University, he/she should have highest level of competence, integrity, morals and institutional commitment. He/She is required to have sound administrative acumen besides being a distinguished person in the field of Music/Art/Culture.

The applicant for the post of Vice-Chancellor may send his/her application Online only in prescribed format available on the website "www.upgovernor.gov.in" on or before 06.08.2026 (Thursday).

Any application received after the prescribed date shall not be considered.

OSD to Governor,
IAS(Retd.)
(Additional Chief Secretary Level),
Uttar Pradesh

UPID Ro.: 253972
R.O. Dt: 22/07/2026
Website: www.up.gov.in

BMSICL Govt. of Bihar

Bihar Medical Services & Infrastructure Corporation Limited
2nd & 3rd Floor, Swasthya Bhawan, Behind IGIMS, Sheikhpura,
Adjacent to State Health Society, Bihar, Patna- 800014
Phone/Fax: +919006405255, +919471009193

TENDER NOTICE

Tender for rate contract and supply of Drugs for different healthcare facilities of state of Bihar

Notice Inviting Tender Ref No.: -BMSICL/DRUGS/26-08
Only through E- Tender on website: - www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in

Bihar Medical Services and Infrastructure Corporation Limited |BMSICL| invites E-Bids from the interested parties for "Tender for rate contract and supply of Drugs for different healthcare facilities of state of Bihar", vide Notice Inviting Tender No.- BMSICL/DRUGS/26-08 Detailed tender document containing eligibility criteria, selection mechanism, other terms and conditions are available on the website www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in.

Tender Schedule

Tender Reference No.	BMSICL/DRUGS/26-08
Date of Pre-Bid meeting	28 th July 2026 at 02:30 P.M. at BMSICL Conference Hall, 3 rd Floor, Swasthya Bhawan, Behind IGIMS, Sheikhpura, Adjacent to State Health Society, Bihar, Patna - 800014
Last date and time of submission of online bids	21 st August 2026 by 05:00 P.M.
Last date and time for submission of EMD and Tender Fees	24 th August 2026 till 02:00 P.M.
Date, Time and Place of opening of Technical Bid	24 th August 2026 (at 03:00 P.M.) on the website of www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in in the office of BMSICL
Date and time of opening of Financial Bids	To be announced later on www.bmsicl.gov.in and www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in
Validity of Tender	180 Days
Cost of the tender document	Rs. 11,800/- (Eleven Thousand Eight Hundred only) Non-refundable.

PR. No. 008359 (B&C) 2026-27

This information is available on website www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar also

अगर मन में हो एच.आई.वी. अथवा यीन जनित रोग से जुड़े सवाल तो बुख्त 1097 पर करें कॉल।



All is not well

The violent incidents following youth protests in Delhi were entirely avoidable

Issue-driven mobilisation by civil society groups tends to remain orderly so long as the government of the day signals that it is willing to listen and engage with genuine concerns. The scenes from Delhi on July 20, when mostly young demonstrators were chased, tear-gassed, and baton-charged within sight of the new Parliament building, with some allegedly struck by pellet guns, while mobile Internet was switched off and Metro stations were shut across the area, were avoidable. The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) march escalated only after the police resorted to force. Had the Union government engaged with the protesters earlier, including activist Sonam Wangchuk, who was on an indefinite fast and forcibly hospitalised two days earlier, the confrontation could have been avoided. A meeting was eventually conceded through Union Minister J.P. Nadda, but only after thousands had reached Parliament’s doorstep. It came too late. That a movement born as online satire could gather millions of digital followers and bring thousands to the street says a great deal about the government’s own record, which has become the source of a litany of grievances. Recurring paper leaks in entrance examinations, the re-conducting of NEET, and the friction over the three-language formula have led to deep concerns that higher education is being administered without accountability by the government.

Yet, it would be a mistake to read the anger as being about examinations alone. Increasingly, the protests have crystallised into a wider discontent over joblessness, stagnant wages and rising prices that weigh on the young across the country. The intensity of the protests also owes much to the Narendra Modi-led BJP government’s disinclination to address genuine civil society concerns except when an election is in view. Course corrections over the last 12-plus years have tended to be timed to the ballot rather than parliamentary sessions or to public disquiet, even as narrow electoral wins in Assembly and parliamentary elections are read as expansive mandates and a licence for an increasingly authoritarian style of rule. The protests, which have drawn support beyond Delhi, are reminiscent of Sri Lanka’s Aragalaya, Nepal’s Gen Z revolt and Bangladesh’s student uprising against authoritarian rule, though their scale and demands remain far narrower in comparison. That should not tempt the government to wait them out. Instead of correcting course, it has sought to reduce the protests to a political duel with the Congress-led Opposition, and to deflect attention from its failures through proxies in civil society and the media. This is self-defeating as it will only deepen youth disillusionment with the democratic system itself. An immediate step is in order. The Union Education Minister, Dharmendra Pradhan, must own the failures on his watch and resign. The alternative is an unceremonious dismissal.

Buried questions

The costs of projects in environmentally fragile zones are many

India is grappling with another Himalayan tragedy. Workers in an under-construction tunnel at the Teesta Stage-VI hydroelectric project of NHPC Limited (formerly National Hydroelectric Power Corporation Private Ltd.), in Sikkim’s Namchi district, struck a pocket of suspected trapped methane. The resulting burst partially damaged the tunnel, killing at least 15 of an estimated 25 workers, with rescue operations still under way. The NHPC has announced a detailed investigation. Methane is a well-recognised hazard in underground excavation, and the geology of the Teesta basin makes it a likely one. The basin sits in a seismically active zone, with young and heavily fractured rock, and where compressed pockets of gas laid down long ago can lie hidden until an excavation breaks into them. The presence of the gas, in that sense, is not in itself surprising. What remains unclear is far more consequential: the precise circumstances in which the pocket was breached, whether its risk was assessed and modelled during project planning, and whether the gas-detection and ventilation safeguards that such conditions demand were in place and functioning.

Underground work in India’s difficult terrain has always been perilous. In February this year, an explosion at an illegal coal mine in Meghalaya killed about 30 workers, and in 2023, a stretch of a road tunnel under construction in Uttarakhand collapsed, trapping 41 workers for 17 days before they were pulled out. The circumstances vary, but together they underscore how lethal underground and tunnelling work remains across the country. A series of hydropower projects along the 400-kilometre stretch of the Teesta that links Sikkim, West Bengal, and Bangladesh have varied histories with environmental clearances but share a common feature – their location in the fragile Himalayan belt. That vulnerability was demonstrated tragically in October 2023, when a glacial lake outburst flood from the South Lhonak lake destroyed the Teesta-III dam and killed more than a 100 people downstream. Teesta-VI was absorbed by the public-sector NHPC Limited after its private developers, unable to afford escalating costs, went into insolvency. Relief and rescue must remain the immediate priority, and every effort to reach those still trapped is warranted. But once the emergency has passed, the government cannot treat the disaster as an isolated misfortune. It must order a thorough, independent review of whether the conditions attached to the project’s environmental clearance were, in practice, strictly met.

How does the cockroach protest alter India’s political landscape? A considerable section of those opposed to the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) sees hope in the mobilisation triggered by the self-deprecating cockroach activists. Some even believe that political parties– particularly the Congress – should fall in line with the outfit that calls itself the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), which took its name from a remark by a judge of the Supreme Court of India who likened India’s disgruntled youth to cockroaches. An opposing view, expressed as hope within the BJP and concern within the Congress, is that this protest could cannibalise the latter. “AAP [the Aam Aadmi Party] finished the Congress in Delhi and Punjab. Let’s see where the CJP ends the Congress,” Devendra Kumar, an election strategist who works with the BJP, posted on X.

The Opposition parties are not unified in their approach to the cockroach protest. Differences exist both between and within parties. The Samajwadi Party and the Left believe that joining the protesters could expand the Opposition space, while within the Congress, opinions are divided over whether playing second fiddle to the protesters would be useful. There are also voices within the Left that favour a more cautious approach. On July 21, the Congress attempted to seize the moment by staging a dharna outside Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s residence.

The politics of public anger

Occasional outbursts of public anger, frustration, and resentment against the government of the day are a normal feature of democratic societies. Whether such sporadic outbursts turn into political mobilisation with electoral consequences is a different question. A protest movement can lead to diametrically opposite outcomes depending on the circumstances. Public anger can be consolidated and galvanised into dramatic electoral outcomes; it can also be diffused through protest, averting or diverting political change.

The Kejriwal-Anna movement of 2011 consolidated public anger against the Congress-led United Progressive Alliance and in favour of the Narendra Modi-led BJP. The Congress bore the brunt of public anger then. Now, the party fears that popular resistance against the ruling BJP, which it believes is snowballing, could be scattered by an apolitical mobilisation without any clear programme or organisation. Those in the Opposition who want to ride with the cockroach protest believe that the protesters are taking aim at the government, and that this sentiment can and should be politicised and amplified through better coordination with them.

Referencing at least three past instances of self-proclaimed apolitical mobilisation may be helpful. The protests against the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA) in 2019-20 and the



Varghese K. George

A movement led by a new generation challenges the BJP’s dominance and reshapes the Opposition’s calculations

farmers’ protests of 2020-21, both of which took place during the second term of the Modi government belong to one category. Before these came the Anna Hazare-Arvind Kejriwal anti-corruption agitation of 2011, followed by the Nirbhaya rape and murder protests of 2012.

There is no way to precisely decipher the social composition of these movements, but some broad features are worth noting. The farmers’ protests were driven largely by relatively prosperous farmers in a narrow belt around Delhi. The anti-CAA protests came to be framed largely as a Muslim issue. An urban middle class that considers itself apolitical took out candles for Anna’s movement and its call to “hang the corrupt at Vijay Chowk”, as it was put, but remained silent during the farmers’ protests and possibly turned against the anti-CAA movement.

By then, its apoliticism had, in many cases, turned into outright communalism. The apolitical middle class periodically finds purpose in declaring all politics illegitimate and undesirable, rallying instead around movements that usually reflect immediate personal grievances – price rise in 2011, question-paper leaks, or the severe income and opportunity stress confronting young people in 2026. Examination irregularities are only the trigger; protesters are agitated by the precarity staring them in the face.

The farmers forced the government to withdraw the controversial farm laws, while the CAA protests fizzled out. Both protests had limited political impact nationally in subsequent elections. They represented sectional interests that the BJP could isolate as the other and amplify its own politics. It is precisely on this point that youth protesters pose an unprecedented challenge to the BJP and an opportunity for the Opposition.

CJP protesters represent a horizontal segment of Indian society, concentrated in the BJP strongholds of the Hindi heartland, where the demographic bulge is manifesting more as disenchantment than hope. It is a segment that cannot easily be cornered as a sectional interest or labelled in any other manner easily by the BJP. It is socially diverse but largely located within the young, Hindu-Hindi spectrum, preempting any communal polarisation on the issue. Anti-corruption slogans were a shell for movements such as the Gujarat Navnirman movement (1974), the JP Movement (1974), and the Anna movement, in which diverse interest groups coalesced to undermine the Congress system.

The difference now

Whether the same pattern of mobilisation that helped bring the BJP and its Hindutva politics to power can also undermine it remains an open question. At its peak in 2019, the BJP secured about 37% of the national vote. At any given point, more than 60% of Indians do not vote for the BJP. If a protest remains confined to a

particular segment of society or a particular region of the country, the BJP remains largely unconcerned. It may even seek a counter-consolidation, as it did during the farmers’ and anti-CAA protests. There is considerable dynamism in the voting preferences of people. The BJP may have lost many of its earlier supporters since 2014 while gaining new ones elsewhere. The ideological appeal of Hindutva remains intact, but the party is also keen to improve its vote-to-seat ratio through a fresh delimitation of Lok Sabha constituencies ahead of the next general election (in 2029).

In the BJP’s scheme of things, it would rather have the CJP in the headlines than Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha and Congress leader Rahul Gandhi. But its toolkits for dealing with protests, which worked earlier, are less effective now, partly because the BJP is dealing with a new generation and its collective psyche. The 20-year-old protester of today was only eight when Mr. Modi became Prime Minister in 2014. It was their parents’ generation that cheered the arrival of the BJP then; their children are now shaking off the burden of their political inheritance. If it was the WhatsApp generation that fuelled the rise of what I term Hindutva 2.0 under Mr. Modi, it is the Instagram generation that is challenging it now. All this makes it possible that this apolitical, sporadic outburst of public anger could expand into a mass mobilisation with sufficient critical weight to unsettle the BJP. What is clear, however, is that the cockroach protesters alone have no capacity to achieve that. That is where the role of the Opposition, particularly the Congress, becomes critical.

A new battleground

The BJP and its Jan Sangh predecessors were able to turn popular mobilisations such as the JP movement and the Anna movement to their advantage and against the Congress, while leaving smaller political gains to figures such as V.P. Singh and Mr. Kejriwal along the way. This is the first time that a comparable phenomenon is being tested against the BJP itself – a party with a stronger ideology, greater organisational discipline, ruthless political determination, and a willingness to deploy state power to its advantage.

The long arc of such apolitical protests has, so far, bent towards the erosion of public trust in the liberal, secular, and untidy middle ground of Indian politics. In that sense, the cockroach protest is more a symptom than a remedy for India’s democratic disarray. Can the Congress do to the BJP what the BJP has done to the Congress over the years through apolitical protests? That is the question before us. Both the BJP and the Opposition face risks as well as opportunities in these protests.

varghese.g@thehindu.co.in

India must lead in securing the Strait of Bab el-Mandeb

On the heels of the Strait of Hormuz crisis comes the new threat – a Strait of Bab el-Mandeb crisis. On July 16, Reuters reported that Iran had instructed the Houthis to close the Strait (which is between Yemen and the Horn of Africa) if the United States attacked Iran’s power plants.

Whether the Houthis have the capacity to threaten the Strait or whether this is part of Iran’s signalling to the U.S. is secondary. What is important is that this represents a risk to one-third of India’s entire trade.

Revisiting 2024

We have been here before. When the Gaza war started in October 2023, the Ansarallah group in Yemen, also known as the Houthis, claimed solidarity with the Palestinians and launched drones and missiles at Israel. From November 2023 to March 2024, the Houthis targeted at least 40 vessels in the Red Sea, claiming that the vessels were linked to or bound for Israel.

In response, the U.S., together with allies including Singapore and Sri Lanka, launched Operation Prosperity Guardian (December 2023) to ensure “freedom of navigation” in the Red Sea. This was followed by United Nations Security Council Resolution 2722 (2024). which was adopted in January 2024. Israel also carried out unilateral strikes against the Houthis. The Indian Navy rescued the crew of a British tanker after it was set on fire (January 26-27, 2024). By the time the U.S declared a ceasefire in May 2025, the Houthis had been weakened, but much of the damage had already been done.

Marine insurance companies tend to be highly risk-averse. With over 90% of the world’s shipping insured by just 12 protection and indemnity (P&I) clubs, shipowners have limited room to negotiate. Between November 2023 and March 2024, at least 2,000 ships avoided the Suez Canal and instead sailed around the Cape of Good



Raja Karthikeya

Adjunct Fellow and lead for West Asia studies at the Takshashila Institution

New Delhi’s leadership can help prevent another major shipping crisis in the Red Sea

Hope. This delayed critical imports to India. Global shipping routes effectively reverted to what was being done 170 years ago. Egypt lost a quarter of the Suez Canal’s revenue. By July 2024, Israel’s Red Sea port of Eilat had filed for bankruptcy.

This time around, the situation is more unpredictable. With U.S. forces in the region focused on Iran, it is unclear whether they will seek to secure the Red Sea as they did before.

Even in 2024, when India-bound ships were attacked by the Houthis, New Delhi had to lean directly on Tehran to bring the attacks to a halt. But that was a different time for India-Iran ties. Meanwhile, the UN Security Council is more divided today than ever before, and even if it manages to call for “freedom of navigation” in the Red Sea, it is unlikely to pass a resolution approving a force to implement that call. China is also likely to again take a unilateral approach to protecting its shipping in the Red Sea through quid pro quos with the Houthis.

If the Houthis resume attacks on shipping in the Strait, the impact on India’s economy – which is already reeling from the Strait of Hormuz crisis – would be dire. While India has now ordered that no Indian mariner be deployed on ships bound to or from the Strait of Hormuz, extending the same restriction to a busy route such as the Strait of Bab el-Mandeb would not be easy and would adversely affect the safety and welfare of thousands of Indian seafarers.

What India should do

In 2024, France stayed out of a U.S.-led operation to guard its role in mediating between Hezbollah and Israel in Lebanon. Those conditions no longer exist. However, France and Japan – two countries that need shipping lanes in the Red Sea for their connectivity with Asia and Europe respectively – maintain bases in Djibouti, perched on the Red Sea. Their navies have also

conducted joint drills with the Indian Navy, which creates an opportunity for India to pre-empt a recurrence of the events of 2024.

India therefore needs to pro-actively build a naval taskforce in collaboration with France and Japan to deter attacks on shipping in the Bab el-Mandeb.

India would also do well to engage Egypt and Saudi Arabia. They had refused to join the alliance against the Houthis in 2024, given their own stance on Gaza. This time, with their economies at stake, they may not stand by. On July 20, the Houthis announced a “maritime embargo” on Saudi ships, seen as a threat against their transit through the Bab el-Mandeb. India needs to engage with these nations proactively to help secure the Red Sea, from the Suez to Bab el-Mandeb, while keeping its other partners in the region informed.

A rules-based maritime response

It needs to be emphasised that this would be a theatre-specific “Trade Protection Task Force” of navies, rather than a strategic alliance. In addition to ships and personnel, the Information Fusion Centre-Indian Ocean Region hosted by India could provide the necessary maritime domain awareness, while France and Japan could complement these efforts with on-ground logistical support. The constituent navies could agree on joint rules of engagement in response to any hostile attacks. They could provide security cover or escorts requested by commercial and civilian vessels transiting the Strait, especially those bound for Europe, India, or Japan. The task force would serve as a lasting demonstration of India’s resolve to ensure “respect for maritime rules and norms” as part of Security and Growth for All in the Region (SAGAR).

India has both the responsibility and the capability to prevent the Bab el-Mandeb from becoming a literal “Gate of Tears” this time.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Protest, political optics

The Congress’s protest is commendable in principle, but its brief, flash-style nature makes it appear more like political posturing than principled activism (Page 1, “Congress leaders detained after dharna at PM’s house”, July 22). If the Congress truly stands with aggrieved youth, it should

demand a transparent inquiry and sustained accountability instead of resorting to brief street theatrics. The larger issue is not which party scores political points, but whether the grievances of the protesters are addressed sincerely and promptly. **Kshirasagara Balaji Rao**, Hyderabad

Specific Articles in the Constitution guarantee the freedom of speech and expression, and the right to assemble peacefully. These rights form the foundation of a democratic society. The government must be accountable to the people, especially to the students whose concerns deserve to be heard with respect. The

larger demand is for accountability, safe and transparent examinations, and a credible exam system that restores confidence among aspirants. **Krish Gupta**, Sonipat, Haryana

The protests have also given rise to confusion and competing narratives. Some

of the public discourse has shifted toward debating hidden agendas and questioning the motives behind the protest. Such discussions risk diverting attention from the central issue – the concerns raised by the students. In moments of public unrest, transparency and verified facts are essential.

Authorities should address legitimate questions through clear communication, while the public should avoid speculation to overshadow genuine grievances. **Shreya Suman Mishra**, Hyderabad

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

From Page One

Delhi HC seeks govt.'s reply on police action

Mr. Sankaranarayanan submitted that despite the Supreme Court's directions in the Ramlila Maidan case (2012) to frame standing orders governing police action during protests, no such SOP had been implemented. "Tear gas, which should be the last resort, was used against students and even mothers carrying children," he said. He also referred to videos allegedly showing lathis fitted with nails and claimed that Additional DCP Sandeep Lamba was seen slapping a woman standing on the sidelines of the protest.

Public anger
Senior advocate Vikas Singh, representing petitioners, submitted that the students had been protesting for nearly 20 days over alleged irregularities in the NEET before deciding to march to Parliament. "The assembly comprised students, doctors, paramedical staff, and others with grievances regarding NEET. It was peaceful and not unlawful. Even if it was unlawful, there is a prescribed method to deal with it," Mr. Singh argued.

Mr. Raju, however, contended that prohibitory orders under Section 163 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita had been promulgated and were widely publicised, including through social media. He described the petitions as "publicity-seeking" and argued that individuals alleging assault should pursue remedies before the jurisdictional magistrates if they believed cognisable offences had been committed. The Bench, however, expressed reservations about treating the allegations as individual instances. "Is it a case of some isolated individual incidents? Perhaps not," the court observed. Mr. Hariharan argued that even if prohibitory orders had been imposed, the police were required to follow established procedures before resorting to force.

Recording that the petitioners had already approached the National Human Rights Commission but had received no response, the Bench directed the Centre to submit its response.

The matter will next be heard on September 11.

10 more deaths raise Assam flood toll to 41

Earlier, replying to a brief discussion on the flood situation in the State Assembly, Parliamentary Affairs Minister Pijush Hazarika said the disaster in Sivasagar, Charaideo, and Jorhat districts, "which rarely experience floods of this magnitude", has been unprecedented. He said the authorities in these districts were caught off-guard after a cloudburst in the adjoining Nagaland triggered a massive flow of water. The cloudburst in Nagaland's Mon district caused multiple landslides, killing at least nine people on July 19.

"These areas are witnessing such a devastating flood in more than 60 years. This is a natural calamity of an unprecedented scale," Mr. Hazarika said.

Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, who toured the affected districts on Wednesday, said the areas that normally experience high floods annually have not been affected much this time. "We have to get to the bottom of the problem and discuss with Nagaland how to deal with it," he said.

Protester hit by pellets could lose vision in right eye: family

Ashna Butani
NEW DELHI

A 19-year-old protester hit by a pellet gun during police action at the Cockroach Janta Party's (CJP) July 20 march to Parliament may lose vision in his right eye, his family said.

Sahil Lochab, a resident of Najafgarh in southwest Delhi, underwent a surgery to remove pellets at the AIIMS Jai Prakash Narayan Apex Trauma Centre on Tuesday. Doctors have informed that there is only a "1% chance" of vision returning in the injured eye as the pupil was damaged, his family said.

Mr. Lochab, who wants to join the police, is a student of Delhi University's School of Open Learning. His mother, Jyoti, said, "He had attended the CJP protests before and went again on Monday, saying it was important and would help his studies... He always wanted to become a police officer. He is pursuing a distance-learning course while preparing for competitive exams."

Ms. Jyoti said that her son will undergo another surgery soon.

Parvesh, a childhood friend of Mr. Lochab, said,



A protester, who sustained pellet injuries, before surgery. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

"Sahil said he was hit directly in his eye. From what we have been told, a second operation for his pupils will determine whether his vision will return to normal." He added that Mr. Lochab is not yet able to see and is in a lot of pain.

Though Delhi Police had denied the use of pellet guns, Mr. Lochab's family said it was told that the injuries were caused by pellets. A hospital source confirmed it.

On Wednesday, *The Hindu* reported that how pellet guns, technically known as pump action guns, were likely used against protesters on July 20.

This was the first known instance of security forces using pellet guns on civilians in Delhi. One of the 80 injured protesters, identified as Shaikh Irshad Mansoori, underwent surgery at Lady Hardinge Medical College on Tuesday to remove a metal pellet lodged under his eye.

Mr. Mansoori will undergo another surgery and is likely to be transferred to another hospital. A hospital source said the pellets that have injured the two were of metal, not plastic.

Pellets guns and shock-batons are part of the gear of the Rapid Action Force (RAF), the specialised anti-riot unit under the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF), which was deployed alongside Delhi Police on Monday in and around Jantar Mantar. RAF, being a Central force, was deployed at the request of Delhi Police and remained under its operational control at the time of incident.

There has been no response from the CRPF on the use of pellet guns.

Meanwhile, Sakshi, 21, who sustained critical injuries during the protest, was removed from ventilator support after she responded to treatment, as per a statement by Ram Manohar Lohia Hospital on Wednesday.

Ministers can meet us at Jantar Mantar, says CJP

As the crowd swells in the heart of Delhi, CJP spokesperson says they refused invite to meet Union Minister Nadda and urged Wangchuk to end fast; some protesters injured in police action back

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Thousands of people continued to pour into the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) protest site at Jantar Mantar in the heart of Delhi on Wednesday, while hundreds more protested outside the entrance towards Sansad Marg.

By late evening, the protesters spilled onto Sansad Marg, the arterial road linking Connaught Place and Parliament House, leading to a stand-off with security personnel. Witnesses said security forces fired at least two tear-gas shells in an attempt to disperse the protesters.

Earlier, CJP chief spokesperson Saurav Das told the media that the police informed them that Union Minister J.P. Nadda wanted to speak to them. "They invited us to his residence, but we declined. A *janata darbar* (public meeting) is being held here, and if the Ministers want to talk, they should come to the people," he said. However, he added that if the government was concerned about security at the protest site,



Voicing out: Cockroach Janta Party supporters protesting at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi on Wednesday. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

Lawyers call for probe

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court Bar Association, the Supreme Court Advocates-on-Record Association, and several Delhi lawyers condemned the police

action on students and sought a probe.

Lawyers providing pro bono legal aid to detained students alleged that the police had neither shared copies of FIRs nor disclosed the names, delaying legal assistance.

vernment. The CJP also requested activist Sonam Wangchuk to end his fast. "Your sacrifice has inspired a generation... We

'Don't waste our time': CJI declines to take cognisance of 'police violence'

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Wednesday declined to initiate *suo motu* proceedings to take cognisance of alleged police excesses during the July 20 crack-down on student protesters in the national capital.

When a lawyer submitted to the Bench that there was videographic evidence of police brutality, Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant orally declined to examine the videos, saying that the court's time

should not be "wasted".

Mentioning the matter before a Bench headed by the Chief Justice, the lawyer urged the court to take cognisance of the alleged police violence.

He pointed out that thousands of students had gathered for the "Chalo Sansad" protest organised by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), demanding fair entrance examinations, reforms in the National Testing Agency (NTA), and the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan

promise that the fight for examination justice will continue until our demands are met," the CJP said in an open letter to Mr. Wangchuk.

At the protest site, as the crowd swelled, announcements were made multiple times to maintain peace. Appeals were made to raise only slogans for Mr. Pradhan's resignation and not any abusive slogans.

Injured, but not scared
Some people came for the protest with visible injuries sustained in police action. Sachin Rawat, 27, with wounds on his forehead and arms, said he was injured the day the police forcibly removed Mr. Wangchuk. "The system should change. *Dharmendra Pradhan ko resign karna padega* [Pradhan has to quit]," he said.

At the venue, Akhilesh Pratap Singh, 22, and others were distributing sandals to people who lost or damaged theirs during the march or at the venue. "I work as a cashier, but have taken leave for the last six days. Till the issue is resolved, I will be here," he said.



Union Health Minister J.P. Nadda addressing a press conference at the BJP headquarters over the government's engagement. PTI

Centre reaches out to Wangchuk; activist seeks protection for protesting students

Nistula Hebbar
NEW DELHI

The government on Wednesday moved up a notch its engagement with protesters against the NEET paper leak, with Union Ministers J.P. Nadda and Jitendra Singh meeting activist Sonam Wangchuk, who responded from hospital with a statement that he was willing to call off the hunger strike if the Centre gave an assurance that no punitive or retaliatory action would be taken against the protesting students.

Mr. Wangchuk's statement also said that the Ministers assured him of "a meaningful discussion in Parliament to ensure accountability, including consideration of the resignation of the Education Minister".

The statement appeared to be a change from earlier, when the resignation of the Education Minister had been the top demand.

Late on Tuesday evening, Mr. Nadda and Mr. Singh, after a marathon meeting with Home Minister Amit Shah, made their way to Medanta Hospital in Gurugram, where Mr. Wangchuk has now been moved for treatment, and, as per sources, urged Mr. Wangchuk to appeal to students to repose faith in the government's process and avoid further escalation.

By evening, Mr. Wangchuk put out his statement, where he noted that he had been visited by around 65 MPs from various political parties who had also urged him to end his strike.

He therefore requested "an unequivocal assurance from the government that none of the young protesters will face any punitive or retaliatory legal action for participating in this movement. Their only "offence" has been to raise their voice for a fair and accountable education system".

Along with States
Sources in the government said they were also going to coordinate with State governments on working out compensation for families that lost their children because of death by suicide attributed to cancellation of the NEET examination.

Addressing a press conference on Wednesday evening, Mr. Nadda, the main interlocutor for the government, said he was in talks with the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), and had met the delegation from that organisation, Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka, in a "good atmosphere" and had asked them to put their demands in writing.

"We are in talks and we will continue to engage," he said but admitted that no meeting with CJP leaders took place on Wednesday.

The Union Minister reiterated that Parliament was the correct forum to discuss the issue threadbare and that it required the government and the Opposition to come up with long-lasting solutions for the paper leakage issue.

The government, therefore, appears to be more proactive in its outreach to quell the storm of protests on the NEET issue.

Over 400 protesters detained in Mumbai; Patna sees clashes

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI/ PATNA

The Mumbai Police detained more than 400 protesters at two locations in the Maharashtra capital during demonstrations demanding action over the alleged NEET paper leak.

Prohibitory orders were enforced at the two venues – Shivaji Park and Dr. Babasaheb Ambedkar Udyan Chowk in Chembur – where protests were organised without prior permission, police sources said.

Shiv Sena (UBT) MLA Aditya Thackeray and Maharashtra Navnirman Sena leader Amit Thackeray visited a police station in Dadar later in the day, following which several of those held were released.

In Bihar capital, the police used batons, water cannons and tear gas to disperse activists of All India Students' Association (AIS), who took out a march seeking the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

Hundreds of AISA activists, joined by local students and members of the Left party's student wing,

Anna Hazare urges Modi to initiate talks

MUMBAI
Dialogue is superior to conflict, social activist Anna Hazare said on Wednesday in a letter to Prime Minister Narendra Modi. He said he was pained by reports of police action and stressed that the government should resolve people's concerns through dialogue and not through suppression.

first gathered at Gandhi Maidan in Patna and tried to march towards Lok Bhavan. At several places, police used water cannons and tear gas to disperse the crowd. However, protesters managed to reach the vicinity of Lok Bhavan and the Chief Minister's residence. They allegedly threw stones at the police, injuring several personnel.

Several protesters were also injured when resorted to baton-charge.

Defending the police action, a senior police officer said the protesters attempted to breach security arrangements.

INDIA bloc MPs stopped from meeting activist in hospital

Ashok Kumar
GURUGRAM

A delegation of 15 MPs from the INDIA bloc was stopped on Wednesday by the Haryana Police from meeting climate activist Sonam Wangchuk at the Medanta Hospital here. The MPs later handed over a letter to his wife Gitanjali J. Angmo, urging the activist to end his fast but continue the protest.

Led by Aam Aadmi Party Rajya Sabha member Sanjay Singh, the delegation said 55 MPs had signed the letter. "There is no permission to meet him and hand over this letter. They are saying it is a medical protocol," Mr. Singh said outside the hospital. He added: "What is the job of the police here? Why are they stopping us? Do they want to kill Sonam Wangchuk?"

The delegation included MPs from Samajwadi Party, Rashtriya Janata Dal, Communist Party of India, and Jharkhand Mukti Morcha. Before it arrived, security outside the hospital was tightened with the deployment of an anti-riot vehicle and a commando squad.

"It is a matter of grave regret that we were not al-



INDIA bloc MPs sitting on the pavement outside Medanta Hospital in Gurugram after the police refused their entry. ASHOK KUMAR

lowed to meet him and it is yet another example of dictatorship," Mr. Singh said. "The court says that he is not under detention, still you can see the huge presence of policemen..." he added.

Samajwadi Party MP Rajeev Rai said Ms. Angmo told them that Mr. Wangchuk wanted to end his fast after receiving their letter. "We were not allowed to meet him and give the letter. It smacks of a conspiracy that the government does not want him to withdraw his fast-unto death," he said.

Speaking outside the hospital, Ms. Angmo said her husband's "vital parameters are fine, but muscle mass is decreasing." "It is not life threatening, but he has weakened," she

said, adding that Mr. Wangchuk had decided to break his fast after receiving the letter but is seeking an assurance from the government that "no injustice is done to protesters." "Sonam has written to Union Ministers J. P. Nadda and Jitendra Singh that he needs assurance that nothing wrong would be done to the students. No FIRs would be registered against them," she said. "This entire agitation is for students and their future, so it is our responsibility that they are not harmed in any way," she said.

Mr. Wangchuk was admitted to Medanta on Tuesday evening and is currently in the ICU, the hospital said in a health bulletin on Wednesday afternoon.

Rahul reassures INDIA bloc allies of close coordination

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Opposition parties need to step up pressure on the government both within and outside Parliament, Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi said on Wednesday, even as he reassured all allies at an INDIA bloc meeting that the Congress believes in better coordination between them.

His remarks come a day after the Congress dharna at Prime Minister Narendra Modi's doorstep, with several allies reportedly upset that they were not kept in the loop about that plan.

At a press conference in the evening, when asked about the Opposition's future strategy and whether the Parliament would function or not, Mr. Gandhi said, "This is a decision for the meeting tomorrow morning. There is a meeting of Opposition leaders, it is disrespectful for me to decide for them. What they will decide we will agree with them," Mr. Gandhi said.

Though several Opposition parties were upset that they were not informed prior to the Congress's protest outside the Prime Minister's residence on Tuesday, sources said that none of them aired



Rahul Gandhi

their displeasure at the meeting on Wednesday; instead, a few privately conveyed it to the Congress.

'A sudden plan'

According to sources, Mr. Gandhi reassured the allies that it was not a deliberate move to keep them out of the loop; instead, he said, the decision was taken suddenly and could not be communicated in time.

Mr. Gandhi, according to sources, emphasised that the Opposition has to adapt its strategy to the changed circumstances and go to the people, he added.

Sources said, on Tuesday, the Congress had initially invited several Opposition leaders to come to party president Mallikarjun Kharge's residence at 3 p.m. Though this invitation was later rescinded, it was explained that there had been a change of plans.

The plans for the protest

at the Prime Minister's doorstep were kept secret and were known only to four or five top Congress leaders. All Congress MPs were then asked to gather at Mr. Kharge's residence at 3 p.m. for a "cake-cutting" ceremony for his 84th birthday. Upon reaching there, Mr. Gandhi informed the assembled MPs that they would march to the rear entrance of the Prime Minister's residence, about 100 metres away. Without waiting for a response from them, he had set off on foot, with the MPs following.

Around 5 p.m., the Congress had reached out to other Opposition leaders. Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav was quick to react. He reached the protest site and was detained along with Mr. Gandhi. Sources said many other leaders also attempted to reach the protest site, but could not get there in time due to heavy traffic. The Trinamool Congress MP Sagarika Ghosh was one such leader.

The Left MPs, meanwhile, declined the invitation. According to sources, Left leaders were upset because, at the Monday morning meeting of the INDIA bloc, they had been the ones to suggest a march to the PM's residence.

Govt. ready for discussion on NEET paper leak: Rijiju

Minister says Speaker will hold consultations and decide rules, date, duration of debate; Congress leader seeks adjournment motion to set aside all other business; demands Pradhan's resignation

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Amid repeated disruptions, Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju on Wednesday told the Lok Sabha that the government was ready for a discussion on the NEET paper leak, even as Opposition parties insisted that Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan resign over the controversy.

The Opposition protests led to repeated adjournments of the House as soon as the proceedings started at 11 a.m. When the Lok Sabha reassembled at noon, Speaker Om Birla asked Mr. Rijiju to make a statement.

Congress leader K.C. Venugopal intervened, saying the Opposition's demand went beyond a discussion and included Mr. Pradhan's resignation.

"Our demand is simple. When the entire nation is feeling the pain of our students, all other business of the House should be set aside and this burning issue should be the top priority for Parliament," Mr. Venugopal said. He demanded that Mr.



Taking questions: Union Minister Kiren Rijiju speaks in Lok Sabha during the Monsoon Session of Parliament on Wednesday. ANI

Asking the Opposition to join the debate in the House, Rijiju says street protests will not yield results

Birla allow an adjournment motion – a parliamentary device where the House adjourns all other business and starts debating the subject for which the motion has been moved.

Responding to him, Mr. Rijiju said the government was ready for a discussion on the issue.

He said the Speaker would hold consultations with floor leaders to decide the rules, date, and duration of the debate.

Disruptions and protest Mr. Birla then said he had heard the views of all sides, as well as the government's willingness to discuss the matter "with an open mind".

He urged the Opposition members to participate in the debate instead of entering the Well of the House and disrupting proceedings.

Amid slogan shouting by the Opposition members, the House was again adjourned till 2 p.m.

The Congress and Samajwadi Party MPs were dressed in black to protest against the alleged paper leak and the police action against demonstrators at Jantar Mantar and elsewhere.

Later, speaking to reporters outside Parliament, Mr. Rijiju said the government was prepared for a "detailed discussion" so that the country could know the steps taken to address the controversy.

The Union Minister accused the Opposition of preferring street protests over a parliamentary debate, saying that issues affecting students and the youth should be discussed in Parliament.

"Street protests will not yield results," Mr. Rijiju said.

Separately, Mr. Pradhan met the Speaker in Parliament House.

The Opposition has been pressing for a discussion on alleged examination irregularities while insisting on Mr. Pradhan's resignation over his handling of the issue.

Opposition and govt. spar over NEET debate in RS

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Repeated adjournments paralysed the proceedings in the Rajya Sabha on Wednesday as the Opposition and Centre fought over the rules governing a discussion on the alleged National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (NEET) question paper leak. While the Opposition demanded a discussion under Rule 267, which requires the suspension of the day's business, the government said no conditions could be dictated.

Deputy Chairman Harivansh read out a ruling that an adjournment motion could be taken up only in the "rarest of the rare" situations. The Opposition argued that the current situation qualified as the "rarest of the rare", adding Union Education Minister must resign before the debate.

The House witnessed repeated sloganeering followed by multiple adjournments and did not take up any agenda. Leader of the Opposition Mallikarjun Kharge tried to raise the issue of the police action against protesters, amid sloganeering by BJP MPs.

Leader of the House J.P. Nadda accused the Opposition of destroying dignity of Parliament through "irresponsible behaviour".

Protesting students are not terrorists, Modi must apologise to them: Rahul

Sandeep Phukan
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi should apologise, Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan must resign and everyone who assaulted the students must be held accountable, Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi said on Wednesday, a day after his dramatic protest outside the Prime Minister's residence.

"They [the students] are our future. They are not terrorists," Mr. Gandhi said at a press conference.

Claiming that there had been 152 examination paper leaks over the past decade, he alleged that about 7.5 crore students had been affected while "there have been zero convictions". "Somebody or a

Opposition in '100% agreement' with the protesters' demands, including Pradhan's resignation, he says

group of people are destroying our education system, India's biggest asset," he said.

'Legitimate demands'

Mr. Gandhi said the Opposition was "100% in agreement" with the protesters' demands, including Mr. Pradhan's resignation, and described them as "legitimate" and "non-negotiable".

At the start of the press conference, the Congress leader played videos showing police action against students during Monday's "Sansad Chalo" protest.

Referring to the visuals, Mr. Gandhi questioned why students demanding a fair education system were subjected to force. "What have they done to have security forces aiming weapons at them, to be beaten up, to be thrashed? They are protesting peacefully, asking for what this country owes them," he said.

Mr. Gandhi reiterated the Congress's charge that the country's education system had been systematically undermined under the Narendra Modi government. "Our education system, which was known to be one of the best in the world, is now a rigged system," he said.

The Congress leader also accused the government of imposing a heavy financial burden on families through an expensive

coaching ecosystem. Citing party estimates, he claimed that Indian families spend about ₹1.32 lakh crore annually on examinations and coaching, nearly matching the Union government's education budget of ₹1.4 lakh crore, only to be told later that examination papers had been leaked.

Calling Mr. Pradhan "incapable" of handling the education portfolio, Mr. Gandhi said the Education Minister had "failed" and should be relieved of his responsibilities.

Asked about his detention and the alleged manhandling by police, Mr. Gandhi brushed aside the issue. "Yes, I was dragged. But, the policemen whispered into my ears to please remove this government," he said.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav on Wednesday said the Opposition had been "forced" to protest outside the Prime Minister's residence as Narendra Modi "refuses to speak in the House".

"If the PM can speak on the students' issue outside Parliament, why can't he make a statement inside the House," he asked, making an intervention when the Opposition parties pressed for Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation over the examination paper leaks and the police crackdown on student protesters.

The SP chief expressed his anguish after Speaker Om Birla initially did not ask him to intervene on the



Akhilesh Yadav, Rahul Gandhi, and other Opposition leaders protest against NEET paper leak at Parliament complex on Wednesday. PTI

issue. "Has there been a deal," an agitated Mr. Yadav asked the Speaker, adding, "The issue is about students, not Congress, BJP or SP. You allowed them to speak."

Amid speculation of a friction within the Opposition, Mr. Yadav clarified that he merely wanted to place the SP's position on

dav said his reference to a "deal" was aimed at the government's alleged "understanding" with the Chair and not at the Congress. They reiterated that any discussion in Parliament should begin only after the Education Minister resigned.

Inside the House, referring to the police action against protesters, he said students were "brutally assaulted" and that the government must take responsibility. "If you don't listen to students, they will come to the streets," Mr. Yadav said, adding, "Women students' clothes were torn, students were hit with lathis, they were left bleeding. Their limbs were broken. Is this the way to treat our students? Will you tear the clothes of our daughters?"

Why so selective on paper leaks, Nadda asks Rahul

Devesh K. Pandey
NEW DELHI

Union Minister J.P. Nadda on Wednesday urged the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, not to be "selective" in citing paper leak cases, saying that such a serious issue should not be exploited for political mileage. He said the government was ready for an in-depth discussion in Parliament, which he described as the most appropriate forum to collectively find lasting solutions.

At a late-evening press conference, Mr. Nadda said: "...I appeal that the issue should not be turned into a political matter... This is a grave problem, and it deserves a serious and in-depth discussion."

He said the NDA government was treating the issue with the utmost sincerity. Reacting to Mr. Gandhi's

press briefing earlier in the day, the Union Minister said Mr. Gandhi quoted a figure of about 150 instances of paper leaks.

"These matters require investigation. This is a responsible government; every issue will be thoroughly examined and all the facts will be placed before the people," he said.

'The list is longer'

Mr. Nadda said Mr. Gandhi did not mention paper leaks and related irregularities under governments led by non-BJP parties, including the Congress.

Claiming the list was much longer, he said some of the leaks had happened in Jammu and Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh, Jharkhand, Telangana, Tamil Nadu, West Bengal, Punjab, Kerala, and Karnataka.

"I want to ask the Leader of the Opposition: why are you being so selective?

This shows that your objective is not the welfare of students... Instead, you want to derive political mileage from students' issues," said Mr. Nadda.

"The Opposition should not keep shifting the goalposts... Children are the country's future and it is the responsibility of both the government and Opposition to safeguard their interests. We should come together to find a permanent solution," he said.

Congress leader Jairam Ramesh termed Mr. Nadda's press conference "a sure sign of the regime's increasing desperation".

"The whole press conference was an unending series of 'what-aboutery'. Mr. Nadda must go beyond such juvenile finger-pointing to first acknowledge the uniquely spectacular nature of Mantri Pradhan's and Pradhan Mantri's failures," he posted on X.

TELANGANA STATE AVIATION CORPORATION LIMITED
GOVERNMENT OF TELANGANA
E-TENDER NOTICE
TENDER No.34/TGSACL/2026
Invites E-Tender for Hiring Twin Engine Helicopter, VIP configuration on wet lease.
The Helicopter should meet all the DGCA requirement for VIP flying.
Interested bidders may download the tender and relevant details from the Website <https://tender.telangana.gov.in>. Tender download from: 24-07-2026.
Last date of submission: 06-08-2026.
DPR R.O. No. 34/PPCL-AGENCY/ADVT/2026-27
For Joint Managing Director

GOVERNMENT OF HIMACHAL PRADESH,
DEPARTMENT OF REVENUE
Disaster Management Cell-HPSDMA,
Program Management Unit
Himachal Pradesh Disaster Risk Reduction and Preparedness Program
HP Secretariat, Shimla,
Phone-0177 2880320/ E-mail-sdma.hp[at]nicdot.jin
Date 21st July 2026
Request for Proposals (RFP)
The Himachal Pradesh State Disaster Management Authority (HPSDMA) invites Request for Proposals (RFPs) under the Himachal Pradesh Disaster Risk Reduction and Preparedness (HPDRRP) Program for the following:
Sr.1. Empanelment of Travel Management Companies/Firms/Agencies to provide travel management and logistical support for official domestic and international travel, exposure visits, training programmes, study tours, accommodation, transportation, visa assistance, and related services.
Sr.2. Selection of Firm(s) for providing Program Audit Services in respect of Anti-Money Laundering (AML) and Countering the Financing of Terrorism (CFT) due diligence under the HPDRRP Program.
The detailed RFP document(s) are available on the HP eProcurement Portal (<https://hptenders.gov.in>). Interested agencies may submit their proposals online. Firms are advised to regularly visit <https://hpsdma.nic.in> and <https://hptenders.gov.in> for corrigenda and updates. The last date for submission of proposals is 17th August 2026 respectively up to 2:00 PM for Sr.1 and 13August 2026 at 02.00 PM for Sr.2.
The undersigned reserves the right to accept or reject any or all proposals without assigning any reason thereof.
-sdl/-
Nishant Thakur (HPAS)
Program Director
HPDRRP Program
HP / 0594/2026-2027

GRIDCO LIMITED
(A Govt. of Odisha Undertaking)
Regd. Office : Janpath, Bhubaneswar-751022, ODISHA
PUBLIC NOTICE

GRIDCO Limited
Janpath,
Bhubaneswar,
Odisha-751022

Objections / Response to Appeal/DFR No. 59/2026; 60/2026; & 61/2026 filed by GRIDCO before the Hon'ble Appellate Tribunal for Electricity, New Delhi against OERC Order dated 13.02.2024, 19.09.2024 and 23.03.2023 respectively, for Truing-up of expenses for FYs 2021-22 and FY 2022-23.

1.GRIDCO Limited has filed Appeal/DFR before the Hon'ble Appellate Tribunal for Electricity, New Delhi against Odisha Electricity Regulatory Commission ("OERC") Order dated 13.02.2024 in Case No. 128 of 2023 (DFR No. 59 of 2026) for Truing-up of expenses for FY 2022-23; Review order dated 19.09.2024 in Case No. 38 of 2024 (DFR No. 60 of 2026) for Truing-up of expenses for FY 2021-22 & FY 2022-23; and order dated 23.03.2023 in Case No. 79 of 2022 (DFR No. 61 of 2026) for Truing Up for FY 2021-22, with respect to specific findings and observations. Hon'ble Tribunal has directed GRIDCO to issue public notice informing the public at large of the filing of the above appeals. The party respondents are OERC and TPCODL, TPWODL, TPNODL & TPSODL. The Appeal/DFR will be listed on 12.08.2026.

2.Copies of the said Appeals/DFRs may be availed by either (a) downloading the soft copy from website of GRIDCO Ltd.(www.gridco.co.in), or (b) requesting a soft copy by email from Mr. Sanjaya Kumar Mishra, CGM (PP)-I/c, GRIDCO Ltd. (cgm.pp@gridco.co.in).

3.Anyone who intends to file Objections / Responses to the Appeal/DFR may file 3 copies of the same at the Registry, Appellate Tribunal for Electricity, 7th Floor, Core IV, SCOPE Complex, Lodhi Road, New Delhi – 110003 before the next date of hearing in the matter along with proof of service on the Appellant addressed to Ms. Abiha Zaidi, Advocate on Record, Supreme Court of India, Office: D-40 (GF), East of Kailash, New Delhi 110065, (M) +9810666702, E-mail abiha@saazpartners.com.

4.The above submissions should be supported by an affidavit in the notified format and should carry the full name, postal address and e-mail address, if any, of the sender. Should the objector wish to be heard in person, he must appear before the Hon'ble Tribunal on 12.08.2026 for which no separate notice shall be issued.
Sd/-CGM (PP)-I/c, GRIDCO Ltd.
4001/214/2627
OIPR-4001/405611/26-27/0017

M CH-CHE

M CH-CHE

INBRIEF



Rupee falls 28 paise to close at 96.53 against U.S. dollar

The rupee depreciated by 28 paise to close at 96.53 against the U.S. dollar on Wednesday, weighed down by surging crude oil prices and heightened geopolitical uncertainty. Forex traders said risk aversion in global markets and a negative trend in domestic equities further dented investor sentiment. At the interbank foreign exchange, the rupee opened at 96.36 against the U.S. dollar and traded in the range of 96.25 to 96.60 during the day. PTI

Dr. Reddy's Q1 net dives 69% to ₹435.6 cr. on lower revenue

Hyderabad-based generic drugmaker Dr. Reddy's Laboratories' consolidated net profit slumped 69% year-on-year (YoY) to ₹435.6 crore in the June quarter amid lower sales of cancer drug lenalidomide and nearly ₹240 crore provision necessitated by recent quality issue around weight loss drug Semaglutide. Total revenue from operations stood at ₹8,099.8 crore (₹8,572.1 crore), showed its results prepared in accordance with Indian Accounting Standards (Ind AS).

Coal India arm BCCL posts June quarter loss at ₹68 cr.

Coal India arm BCCL on Wednesday reported a loss of ₹68.09 crore for the June quarter due to lower revenue and higher expenses. However, the company had reported a profit of ₹176.87 crore in the year-ago period, Bharat Coking Coal Ltd. (BCCL) said in a filing with the BSE. Revenue from operations during the first quarter of the current fiscal year declined to ₹3,587.27 crore over ₹3,719.59 crore in the corresponding quarter of the previous fiscal year. PTI

Centre considering to lift restrictions on airport ownership

The current rules cap airline ownership in airports and are inferred to similarly restrict airport operators from owning airlines

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI

The Centre is considering removing restrictions on cross-ownership between airport operators and airlines, a move that could allow airport companies to own airlines and airline groups to acquire stakes in airports, according to people familiar with the matter.

“The Ministry of Civil Aviation is preparing a concept note for consultations with NITI Aayog and other government ministries on the proposed changes,” a person aware of the discussions said, adding that such a proposal would need the final nod from the Union Cabinet.

The proposal comes amid Air India's interest in expanding into the airport business, one person aware of discussions added but senior Air India sources denied it. Air India is jointly owned by Tata Sons, which holds a 74.9% stake, and Singapore Airlines, which owns the remaining 25.1%.

Some existing airport concession agreements impose limits on airline ownership. For instance, the concession agreements for the Noida International Airport and Navi Mumbai International Airport projects provide that no sche-



Myriad of protocols: The ownership restrictions are even tighter for Delhi and Mumbai airports. REPRESENTATIONAL PHOTO

duled airline, cargo airline or their associates may hold more than 26% of the subscribed and paid-up equity of the concessionaire.

The ownership restrictions are even tighter for Delhi and Mumbai airports. Under the original privatisation framework, the aggregate equity held by all Indian scheduled airlines was capped at 10%, while foreign airlines were not permitted to hold any equity in the airport operating companies.

These restrictions also operate in reverse, effectively preventing airport operators from owning or controlling airlines. The Adani Group, which operates eight airports and has businesses spanning ports, power and renewable energy, has so far maintained that it has no interest in entering the airline business amid growing discussions around the dominance of Air India and IndiGo, which have a duopoly

Trump's 200% generic tariff threat would imperil Americans: Indian pharma

N. Ravi Kumar
HYDERABAD

U.S. President Donald Trump has given generic pharmaceutical companies a two-year window to establish manufacturing facilities in the United States, warning that products imported after August 2028 could face tariffs of up to 200%.

The announcement, made on Wednesday through a social media post, has significant implications for India, which sends more than a third of its pharmaceutical exports to the U.S. While Indian drugmakers sought to strike a cautious note, they warned that higher tariffs would ultimately increase medicine costs for American consumers.

Mr. Trump said the measure is intended to encourage generic drug production in the U.S. and reduce dependence on overseas supply chains.

“Effective August 1, 2026, all generic drugs being brought into the United States will continue to have a tariff of zero per cent for a two-year period of time, after which the tariff will be raised to 100% for a one-year period of time, and 200% thereafter,” he said. The announcement rattled pharmaceutical stocks. The Nifty Pharma index fell 1.31%, with 18 of its 20 constituent companies closing lower.

“It’s not practical to move operations like that to the U.S. overnight. If ta-

significantly cheaper than branded alternatives. However, large-scale relocation of generic drug manufacturing to the U.S. would be challenging, given the industry’s reliance on global supply chains and imported active pharmaceutical ingredients.

Granules India Executive Director Priyanka Chigurupati said the company’s three U.S. facilities position it well to support increased local manufacturing. However, she cautioned that higher generic drug prices could ripple across the healthcare system and affect patient affordability.

Indian Pharmaceutical Alliance Secretary General Sudarshan Jain said Indian companies already have a substantial U.S. presence, with more than 40 facilities supporting jobs, manufacturing and research. India, he said, remains a trusted partner in supplying affordable, quality medicines to American patients. GTRI added that building a fully domestic pharmaceutical supply chain in the U.S. would require significant investment and would almost certainly lead to higher medicine prices.

“The zero-tariff window gives the industry a meaningful runway, and we see this as time we can use productively – to keep strengthening our position across multiple markets rather than relying on any single one,” said Pharmexcil Chairman Namit Joshi.

ribs are imposed, we will have to raise prices,” said Dr. Reddy’s Laboratories CEO Erez Israeli. He added that the company was not planning any immediate changes and noted that policy positions could evolve over time.

‘India most exposed’

According to the Global Trade Research Initiative (GTRI), India is among the countries most exposed to the proposed measure. India exported pharmaceutical products worth \$25.8 billion in 2025, of which \$9.7 billion, or 37.7%, went to the U.S. its largest overseas market.

Indian firms account for nearly 47% of all generic prescriptions dispensed in the U.S., making India the largest supplier of affordable generic medicines.

Despite this dominance, generics’ low pricing means India’s share of the value of U.S. generic imports is estimated at only about 30%.

The U.S. imported pharmaceutical products worth \$213 billion in 2025, including \$94.1 billion worth of finished medicines sold in retail packs. GTRI founder Ajay Srivastava said many Indian generics could remain competitive despite the tariffs because they are

Economy navigated external uncertainties well: RBI bulletin

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Indian economy has navigated well the external uncertainties and supply chain pressures, underpinned by healthy demand conditions and resilient performance of industrial and services sectors, according to a Reserve Bank of India (RBI) bulletin.

“The global economy is dealing with uncertain economic environment, supply chain disruptions and fragmented trading relationships. Amid these uncertainties, India remains among the fastest growing major economies across the globe and has been able to sustain the momentum in economic activities through June,” senior offi-

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

State-owned oil-marketing company Bharat Petroleum posted a loss of about ₹3,962 crore in the June-ended quarter that was marred by elevated crude prices on account of the conflict in West Asia.

Benchmark global crude prices during the pe-

riod stayed elevated as the conflict disrupted the supply route, that is, the Strait of Hormuz that accounts for one-fifth of the global energy trade.

Revenue rises 23%

The Mumbai-headquartered refiner’s revenue, though, rose more than 23% year-on-year basis to about ₹1.61 lakh crore.

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

State-owned oil-marketing company Hindustan Petroleum posted a net loss of about ₹12,265 crore in the June-ended quarter on supply route disruptions due to West Asia conflict.

Benchmark global crude prices had breached the \$100/barrel mark for a

Benchmark global crude prices had breached the \$100/barrel mark for a prolonged period

prolonged period with the conflict having choked the Strait of Hormuz, which accounts for one-fifth of the global energy trade.

The Mumbai-based refiner’s revenue climbed about 21% year-on-year to ₹1.45 lakh crore.

Sales – inclusive of the exports – increased 0.6% from the comparable period last year to 13.12 MMT. Combined sales of petrol and diesel increased 8.1% during the period.

IndianOil is scheduled to publish results July 31.

Net FDI negative in May on \$74 million excess outflow

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

Net foreign direct investment (FDI) inflows turned negative once again in May with outflows exceeding inflows by \$74 million, according to the latest Reserve Bank of India data.

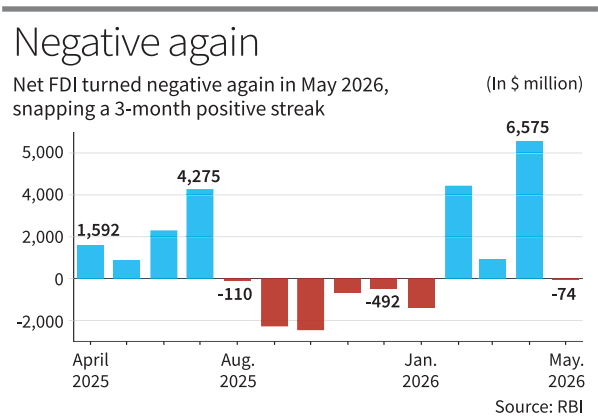
This snapped a three-month streak of positive net inflows and was driven by a sharp drop in direct investment entering India.

That is, even though outflows fell, inflows fell by a larger amount.

As per the data, the total direct investment entering the country, or gross inflows, stood at about \$6.07 billion in May 2026. This was 60% lower than in April and nearly 23% lower than in May last year.

The RBI’s commentary did not speak about May on a standalone basis but instead focused on the April-May 2026 period.

During this period, it said Japan, Singapore, and Mauritius accounted for about 74% of the total equity inflows with financial services receiving the high-



est share, followed by manufacturing, retail and wholesale trade and computer services. It added these sectors together accounted for about 80% of total inflows.

Total outflows

Total outflows stood at \$6.14 billion in May 2026, lower than in April 2026 and May of last year. But total outflows exceeded total inflows by \$74 million.

Within the outflows, outward investment by Indian firms stood at \$2.4 billion in May this year, 49% lower than in April and 9.6% lower than May 2025.

“Of the outward FDI, around 74% of the flows were directed towards the U.S., Cayman Islands and the Netherlands; the major sectors included financial, insurance and business services and manufacturing, accounting for more than 85% of the outward flows during April-May 2026,” the RBI said.

The other component of outflows, repatriation and disinvestment by foreign companies operating in India, stood at \$3.7 billion in May 2026. This was 5.1% lower than in April and 13.3% lower than in May of last year.

TIRUMALA TIRUPATI DEVASTHANAMS - TIRUPATI
e-AUCTION NOTIFICATION TENDER

e-Auction for Sale of Press Jelly, Office Sweeping / records etc., (As-it-is where-it-is condition) in TTD Press. For Tender Notice & details, please see the Auction Id: 26261. Roc. No. P2/36/Press/2014. Please log on to the website <http://www.tirumala.org> and <https://konugolu.ap.gov.in>. For further details contact: 0877-2264292.

TTD-40021(31)/1/2026-PRO SEC(Adv.No.123) Date:22-07-2026 **EXECUTIVE OFFICER**

SANJAY GANDHI INSTITUTE OF TRAUMA AND ORTHOPAEDICS
(Government of Karnataka Autonomous Institute)

Byrasandra, Jayanagara East, Bengaluru - 560 011 Ph: 080-26564516, 26562500 Grams: SITO Fax: 26565222 E-mail: sitodirector@gmail.com No. SGITo/e-Tender/ME/X-Ray/340/2026-27 Date: 22-07-2026

TENDER NOTIFICATION
(Through KPP Portal only)

Sanjay Gandhi Institute of Trauma & Orthopaedics, Byrasandra, Jayanagara East, Bengaluru - 11 invites tender from the eligible tenderers through the KPP portal of GOK for the following.

Sl No.	Description
1.	SUPPLY, INSTALLATION AND COMMISSIONING OF MEDICAL EQUIPMENTS ON TURNKEY BASIS
2.	No. SGITo/e-Tender/X-Ray/FMS/66/2026-27 SUPPLY OF ORTHOPANTOMOGRAM (OPG) X-RAY MACHINE - 1 No.
3.	No. SGITo/e-Tender/Micro Drill/15/2026-27 SUPPLY OF MICRO DRILL SYSTEM - 2 Nos.
4.	SGITo/e-Tender/BMW/14/2026-27 DISPOSAL OF BIO MEDICAL WASTE SERVICES

(1) The Tenderers can download the documents from: <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in/> on or after **23-07-2026** and the last date for submission of completed tenders through e-portal is **07-08-2026** upto **4:00 PM**.

(2) The Tender Accepting Authority reserves the right to accept / reject or cancel tender without assigning any reason thereof.

Sd/- Director
Tender Inviting Authority
DIPR/SI/1767/2026-27

कार्यालय अतिरिक्त मुख्य अभियंता सा.नि.वि. संभाग कोटा
क्रमंक: 1051 दिनांक: 20.07.2026

संशोधित निविदा संख्या-09/2026-27

इस कार्यलय के चार्ज 776 दिनांक 17.06.2026 के द्वारा प्रकाशित निविदा सूचना संख्या-09/2026-27 अविलंब कार्यों से निम्न संशोधन किया जाता है।

क्र. सं.	विवरण	पूर्व से	अब यह क्या जावे
1	निविदा फॉर्म फिलने एवं जमा करने की तरिख	29.06.2026 से 20.07.2026 सार्व 6.00 बजे	29.06.2026 से 23.07.2026 सार्व 6.00 बजे
2	ऑनलाइन तकनीकी निविदा खोलने की तरिख	22.07.2026 अपराह्न 3.00 बजे	24.07.2026 अपराह्न 3.00 बजे
3	अंतिम प्रौढी जमा करने की तरिख	21.07.2026 सार्व 4.00 बजे	24.07.2026 दोपहर 12.00 बजे

निविदा की अन्य शर्तें यथावत रहेंगे।
UBN No.: PWD2627WLOB05240
DIPR/C/12800/2026

अतिरिक्त मुख्य अभियंता सा.नि.वि. संभाग कोटा

Government of Rajasthan
Superintendent shri kalyan govt. hospital sikar
Email- pmo_sikar@yahoo.in Date- 17-07-2026

No. SKH/Store/NT/2026-27/214 E-Tender Notice Invitation No. 03/2026

Online Bids are invited from the registered bidders of appropriate category for supply of the following items:-

S.N.	Name of Item	Estimated bid value (Rs.) including all taxes	Last date of online submission of bid	Technical bid of opening
1	Rate contract for medicine under MNDY	400.00 lac	10/08/2026	11/08/2026
2	Rate contract for surgical & suture under MNDY	200.00 lac	10/08/2026	11/08/2026

Note:- 1. Detailed bid document can be download from <http://sppp.raj.nic.in> & <http://proc.rajjasthan.gov.in>
2. Bid fees EMD and processing fee will be as per bid document and rtp rules 2013.
3. Other details specification, conditions are as per the detailed bid document.
1. NIB CODE- MHS2627A1987 2. UBN CODE- MHS2627GLOB02618
3. UBN CODE- MHS2627GLOB02919
DIPR/C/12768/2026 **Superintendent Shri Kalyan Govt. Hospital Sikar**

BANGALORE ELECTRICITY SUPPLY COMPANY LIMITED
(Wholly Owned Government of Karnataka Undertaking)
CIN-U04010KA2002SGC030438

SHORT TERM TENDER NOTIFICATION (Through KPP Portal)

BESCOM invites tender against **Tender Enquiry No: BESCOM/2026-27/SE0471** Annual Maintenance of Distribution Transformer Life Cycle Management Software (DTLMS) for a period of Three years.

Availability of bid document: **24.07.2026 From 15:00 hrs** on or after. Last date for receipt of bids: **10.08.2026 Up to 15:00 hrs**

The detailed notification can be obtained from the Website: <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>. Further details can be obtained from the office of the undersigned.

For Electricity related complaints call: 1912 **Sd/- General Manager (DAS, SG & TIC) BESCOM, Bengaluru.**
Download BESCOM Mittra Mobile APP

ZAWTAR AL-GHARBIYAH

Lebanon PM says Beirut working for ‘complete Israeli withdrawal’



Lebanon is working towards a “complete Israeli withdrawal” from areas it occupies, Prime Minister Nawaf Salam said on Wednesday on a visit to a village where Lebanon’s army recently deployed. “We will continue mobilising our political and diplomatic efforts to secure a complete Israeli withdrawal from the south.” AFP

NEW YORK

U.S. court sets June 2027 trial for Venezuela’s ousted leader Maduro



Venezuela’s ousted President Nicolas Maduro will go on trial in the United States on June 1, 2027, a judge ruled on Wednesday, after his capture in a U.S. military raid in January. The former leader and wife, Cilia Flores, have been held in a Brooklyn jail after pleading not guilty to drug trafficking and firearms charges. AFP

MANILA

Allowing Iran to control Hormuz ‘dangerous precedent’, says Rubio



U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio told Southeast Asian Foreign Ministers on Wednesday that Iranian control of the Strait of Hormuz would set a dangerous precedent with repercussions beyond the West Asia. Mr. Rubio’s remarks came as the region is grappling with claims by China and ASEAN members in the South China Sea. AFP

KABUL

Pak. strike on Kabul drug treatment centre may be war crime: Amnesty



A Pakistani air strike that hit a drug treatment centre in the Afghan capital Kabul in March, killing hundreds of civilians, should be investigated as a possible war crime, human rights organisation Amnesty International says. It said it had “found no evidence to support” Pakistan’s claims of it being used for military purposes. AP

Trump vows to hit a bridge or power plant in Iran for each Hormuz attack

U.S. leader’s threat comes during the 11th consecutive night of U.S. strikes on Iran, with attacks targeting aircraft hangars and drone storage sites; Jordan says it intercepted four missiles and four drones, with two missiles falling in ‘uninhabited areas’

Associated Press
DUBAI

U.S. President Donald Trump has warned Iran that the U.S. will destroy one bridge or power plant each time Iran shoots at a ship in the Strait of Hormuz. The warning came after the U.S. carried out another wave of strikes on Iran, where air defences opened fire over the capital, Tehran. Iran launched a missile attack on a Jordanian city on Israel’s doorstep, and alerts were issued in Bahrain and Saudi Arabia. In his warning on social media, the President returned to earlier threats to

target civilian infrastructure in retaliation for Iranian attacks. “From this point forward, any time the Islamic Republic of Iran shoots at a ship in the Strait of Hormuz, whether it be by Missile, Rocket, Drone, or any other device or weapon, the United States will bomb and destroy ONE BRIDGE OR POWER PLANT,” Mr. Trump wrote on social media. The U.S. military said the 11th night of air strikes on Iran targeted aircraft hangars and drone storage sites, as diplomatic efforts have shown little public sign of progress. Officials on both sides have dug in



Donald Trump during a dignified transfer solemn event for troops killed in West Asia, at Dover Air Force Base in U.S. on Wednesday. AFP

on their dispute over the Strait of Hormuz, a crucial waterway for global energy that remains largely closed because of Iranian attacks. Israel since hostilities resumed last month, apparently hoping to keep it from re-entering the war. But the missile and drone attack on Jordan’s city of

Aqaba, within sight of Israel’s Eilat, raised concerns over a further widening of the conflict after an agreement to halt hostilities collapsed. Jordan’s military said it intercepted four Iranian missiles over Aqaba, while two others fell in “uninhabited areas”. Plumes of smoke could be seen overhead in videos filmed by people in the nearby Israeli city of Eilat. Jordan said it also intercepted four Iranian drones. Another missile alert sounded in Bahrain, and Saudi Arabia warned residents of Dammam to seek shelter. Authorities later said danger had passed.

Zelenskyy fires Army chief and names a replacement

Associated Press
KYIV

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy on Tuesday fired Gen. Oleksandr Syrskyy as commander-in-chief of the armed forces and named his replacement, following days of mass protests in Kyiv, the country’s capital, and other cities across the nation demanding his removal. It was the second major change Mr. Zelenskyy has made under street pressure, after protests last summer forced him to undo a law weakening Ukraine’s anti-corruption watchdogs. Mr. Zelenskyy appointed Mykhailo Drapatyi as the new army chief, according to a statement on social media. “Our shared wish is one – victory over



Acting Defence Minister Yevhenii Khmara with commander-in-chief of Ukraine’s armed forces Mykhailo Drapatyi on Wednesday. REUTERS

the enemy and conditions at the front and in pressure on Russia that would force Russia toward peace,” Mr. Zelenskyy said. The Ukrainian leader said he made the decision after a series of meetings with military commanders. They began shortly after protests broke out demanding the reinstatement of former Defence Minister Mykhailo Fedorov, seen by demonstrators as a driver of military modernisation, and the removal of Gen. Syrskyy. Mr. Zelenskyy thanked Gen. Syrskyy for his achievements in Ukraine’s fight against Russia and praised him for the defence of Kyiv.

Saudi, UAE ministers signal unity after months of tension

Reuters
RIYADH

Senior Saudi and United Arab Emirates officials on Tuesday shared similar social media posts affirming their close historical ties and “wise leadership”, a move that follows months of tensions owing to a rift between the two Gulf monarchies. The posts on X by Saudi Minister of Media Salman Al-Dosary and Abdulla bin Mohammed Alhamed, Chairman of the UAE National Media Authority, were both released at 7 p.m. Riyadh time. “Emirati-Saudi relations are an extension of a shared history and deep-

The move follows months of tensions owing to a rift between the two Gulf monarchies rooted fraternal ties between two brotherly peoples, united by a single destiny,” Mr. Alhamed wrote. “The relationship between the Kingdom and the Emirates is a relationship between two peoples united by a shared history and heritage, and wise leadership in both countries,” Mr. Al-Dosary’s post said. Both posts said media should reflect those aspects of relationship and avoid undermining them.

U.S. to announce nuclear agreement with Saudi Arabia

Agence France-Presse
WASHINGTON

The United States plans to announce a landmark deal with Saudi Arabia on Wednesday that would help establish a civilian nuclear programme in the kingdom, according to media reports. The move comes as Washington fights a war with Iran that began in part over U.S. concerns with Tehran’s own nuclear program – an issue that remains a key point of contention during now-stalled talks between the two foes. The New York Times, citing two unidentified U.S. officials, reported on Tuesday that the Trump administration planned to formally sign and announce the deal with the Saudis on Wednesday. President Donald Trump’s administration said the agreement would provide billions of dollars for the U.S. nuclear industry. A provision in the 30-year deal would potentially see U.S. companies build a uranium enrichment facility in Saudi Arabia, the Wall Street Journal reported. However, U.S. lawmakers from both parties and Israeli officials have voiced opposition to a civilian nuclear project for Saudi Arabia over fears it could be converted to eventually develop nuclear weapons.

Mamdani says NYC cannot arrest Netanyahu, urges federal govt. to act

Associated Press
NEW YORK

New York Mayor Zohran Mamdani said late Tuesday that the city would not be able to execute an arrest warrant issued by the world’s top war-crimes court for Israel’s Benjamin Netanyahu, but urged the federal government to do so. In the video, Mr. Mamdani described the Israeli Prime Minister as a “war criminal” and said he is not welcome in New York City. “It is clear that we do not have the independent legal authority to enforce this warrant,” he said in a video posted on X. “The federal government however does and I call on



New York City Mayor Zohran Mamdani speaks about Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu in video on Tuesday. REUTERS

them to join the ICC and execute this warrant,” he added. Mr. Mamdani had told the New York Times earlier this month that he and the city’s legal department were discussing arresting Mr. Netanyahu if he comes

the United States of America.” Mr. Mamdani had said throughout his mayoral election campaign last year that he would seek to order the city’s police to arrest Mr. Netanyahu under the criminal court’s warrant over Mr. Netanyahu’s role in the war in Gaza. In his video message on Tuesday, Mr. Mamdani said his administration has reviewed all avenues available and determined the city can’t execute the arrest warrant. Danny Danon, the Israeli ambassador to the UN, responded by telling the mayor “enough”. “You were elected to serve New Yorkers, not Hamas’ propaganda,” he said.

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DECISIVE FACTOR

Ready infrastructure sealed India's 2030 CWG bid: Sadleir



COMMONWEALTH SPORT

Ahmedabad's ready-made world-class sporting infrastructure played a decisive role in securing the hosting rights for the centenary 2030 Commonwealth Games, said Commonwealth Sport CEO Katie Sadleir, adding that the bid perfectly aligned with the governing body's revamped low-cost hosting model.

FULL OF OPTIMISM

Vishal focused and all geared up for a good show at Glasgow



FILE PHOTO: RITU RAJ KONWAR

I'm entering the Commonwealth Games with a mindset to win. Months of hard work, honesty, discipline, consistency and self-belief have brought me to this stage, and I trust the process. Representing India is the biggest motivation, and I'll give everything I have to make the nation proud — 400m National champion Vishal.

PRIORITIES

Animesh not fretting over losing the tag of India's fastest man



FILE PHOTO: RITU RAJ KONWAR

Animesh Kujur isn't losing sleep over surrendering the tag of India's fastest man to Gurindervir Singh. Instead, the National record-holder in the 200m wants his performances at the Commonwealth Games and Asian Games to do the talking. "Just waiting for Asian Games. Then we'll talk again," Animesh said.

LEARNING CURVE

Knowledge transfer as important as doing well at the Games: Rajpal



PTI

Both the Games side and the non-Games side at Glasgow are equally important. There will be knowledge-transfer programmes on the sidelines so we can match or better things when we host the next Games in India. We will also be taking back the flag and the baton — India's Chef de Mission Rohit Rajpal.

Can Indian athletes punch up in the scaled-down Games?

Leading the country's charge will be javelin ace Neeraj, who will face stiff competition from Pakistan's Nadeem; the number of disciplines has been cut from 19 to 10 as the event tries to stay relevant

C'WEALTH GAMES

K. Keerthivasan
GLASGOW

Victoria's decision to pull out of hosting the Commonwealth Games (CWG) in July 2023, citing unsustainable costs, plunged the multi-sport event into uncertainty. There were fears that the 2026 Games might not be held at all. For nearly a year, the search for a replacement host went on. Gold Coast, the 2018 host, along with Singapore and Malaysia, figured prominently before Glasgow officially stepped up in September 2024 to host the event, returning after its successful staging of the 2014 Games.

Realising the spiralling organising costs, Glasgow tactfully cut the number of disciplines to 10 across four venues, a considerable reduction from Birmingham 2022 where 19 sports were staged across 15 venues. In many ways, the Glasgow Games beginning on Thursday can be credited with saving the multi-sport event from losing its relevance.



Ready to rumble: India will have high hopes from boxer Lovlina while Sreeshankar and Tejaswin will also look to bring home a medal. PTI, SUDHAKARA JAIN & FILE PHOTO

Describing it as the 'Reimagined Games', George Black, Chair, Glasgow 2026, and Phil Batty, Chief Executive Officer, wrote: "Glasgow 2026 is being realised with 150 million pounds of investment. The competition is being entirely privately funded. A

self-sustaining, ground-breaking Games delivery model." It might be a scaled-down Games, but make no mistake there will be no shortage of star power, including Olympic medalists, world champions and reigning CWG title-holders.



Leading India's charge will be Tokyo Olympics gold medalist and former world champion Neeraj Chopra in the men's javelin. The Indian ace will be challenged by Pakistan's Arshad Nadeem, the Paris Olympic champion and defending CWG titlist.

The athletics discipline will be headlined by Scotland's reigning world mile record holder Josh Kerr, and England's Katarina Johnson-Thompson, the 2023 world champion and Paris Olympics silver medalist in the heptathlon. Jamaica's Danielle Wil-



liams, the 2023 world champion in the women's 100m hurdles, and Kenya's Faith Cherotich, the Paris Olympics bronze medalist in the women's 3000m steeplechase, are also among the biggest names set to light up Glasgow. India's medal hopes in

athletics will also rest on Tejaswin Shankar (decathlon), M. Sreeshankar (long jump), and Parul Chaudhary (5000m and 3000 SC). Will Indian athletes be able to overhaul their 2022 medal tally of eight or surpass their best medal haul

of 12 from the home CWG in 2010? A sizeable share of India's medals will also come from boxing and weightlifting.

At Birmingham, Indian boxers won seven medals while the weightlifters returned with 10.

In the boxing ring, Lovlina Borgohain, the Tokyo Olympics bronze medalist, will be looking for her maiden CWG medal. The others to keep an eye on are Jaismine Lamboria (57kg) and Sachin Siwach (60kg).

In weightlifting, Mirabai Chanu (48kg) will be aiming to complete a historic hat-trick of CWG gold medals. Harjinder Kaur (71kg), Bindyarani Devi (58kg), Gyaneshwari Yadav (53kg) and S. Sanjana (63kg) are among India's other leading medal hopes.

Transforming fortunes

The Games had transformed the fortunes of several Indian sportspersons in ways even they scarcely could have imagined. Shashank Kamal, Mirabai and Manika Batra are among the finest examples.

Will the 'Reimagined Games' produce a few more young Indian stars?

A great platform to make a name for yourself: Rasquinha

Uthra Ganesan
NEW DELHI

As a truncated 2026 Commonwealth Games kicks off on Thursday, most of the stakeholders admit the medal rush may not be as prolific but insist there is no lack of incentive for those participating.

"I think it's going to be a very different Commonwealth Games because a lot of our medal-winning sports are missing. Last two CWG, we won 12 medals in wrestling, six in badminton, seven in table tennis, two each in hockey and squash — none of them is there. So it's 100% going to affect our medal tally.

"(But) in terms of position on the table, I think it'll still be Australia and England at the top, by far the strongest at this level. For the third place, which India ideally should be aiming for, it's always a battle with New Zealand and Canada. What's going to be really important is, can we win those gold medals?" former India captain and CEO of Olympic Gold Quest Viren Rasquinha said in an interaction on Wednesday.

He admitted it was disappointing but added that most sports have other important events ongoing, ensuring there was no drop in terms of competitive exposure ahead of the Asian Games.

"Currently, all our top



Raring to go: Neeraj would strive to regain the Commonwealth Games crown. GETTY IMAGES

shooters are at the Rifle & Pistol World Cup in Hangzhou. In table tennis the UTT is on, there will be the hockey World Cup and the badminton World Championships.

"For those participating, I totally disagree with the notion that the Commonwealth Games is not of value.

"As athletes and coaches, you always respect every competition and as an opportunity to participate and do well for younger players, the Commonwealth Games is a great platform to make a name for yourself."

Asked about his medal expectations, Rasquinha

refused to put a number. "I'm never one for making predictions. If you look at what's happened in Indian athletics recently, there have been about 26 National records in the last 6-12 months. So, I think athletics is one sport where we can look at 8-10 medals. The women's boxing squad is so strong this time, all seven participants are capable of winning medals. Weightlifting, again, we can expect 8-10."

(The interaction was facilitated by Sony Sports Network, the official broadcasters of the Commonwealth Games 2026. Tune-In: Day 1, July 24 from 1 p.m IST live on Sony Sports Ten 2 SD & HD).

Mirabai need not push for third gold: coach Vijay

WEIGHTLIFTING

Y.B. Sarangi
KOLKATA

Olympic and World championships medalist Mirabai Chanu need not push herself to claim her third consecutive gold at the Glasgow Commonwealth Games, said National chief coach Vijay Sharma.

Mirabai totalled 205kg at the National championships at Modinagar in February before pulling out of the Asian championships at Gandhinagar in May due to a shoulder injury.

The soon-to-be 32-year-old will be eyeing her fourth CWG medal of any colour in a row in Glasgow while trying to stay injury-free. Since an Asian Games medal has eluded Mirabai, the continental Games in Aichi-Nagoya, from September 19 to October 4, would be her priority.

Vijay said it would not be prudent to push her in the women's 48kg competition in Glasgow.

"For Mira, the CWG will be like a practice event before the Asian Games. A total of 190-195kg should be enough for her to win the CWG gold medal. Irrespective of the total, a gold is a



Hard at work: The coach feels that CWG will be like a practice event for Mirabai as she targets a medal at the Asian Games. FILE PHOTO: SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

gold. Her main target is medalling at the Asian Games," Vijay told *The Hindu*.

Mirabai had won the

Commonwealth championships title in Ahmedabad by a margin of 32kg after aggregating 193kg.

Apart from Mirabai, V.

Ajaya Babu (79kg) will be in the race for a gold medal. M. Raja (65kg) has an outside chance of finishing on top of the podium.

Following four positive dope tests, including that of gold medal prospect N. Ajith (71kg), which led to a reduction in the country's quota places, it will be challenging for the Indian weightlifting squad to replicate its 10-medal performance of the Birmingham Games four years ago.

The 12-member Indian weightlifting team trained at Wolverhampton University in Birmingham for more than three weeks before moving to Glasgow.

Challengers end UTT league stage on top

Amol Karhadkar
PANAJI

The gulf between the table-topper and the bottom-placed side was evident as Dempo Goa Challengers finished the league stage with a commanding 10-5 victory over UP Prometheans in Ultimate Table Tennis Season 7 at the Dr. Shyama Prasad Mukherjee Indoor Stadium on Wednesday.

With both sets of owners employing *dhol-tasha* bands to rally their teams, the atmosphere was festive. But on the table, the contest was largely one-way traffic in favour of the home side.



On song: Szocs played a key role for the Challengers. BUTTERFLYUTT

Despite being assured of the top spot, Goa resisted the temptation to rotate its squad and instead fielded its strongest combination. Experienced campaigners Alvaro Robles and Bernadette Szocs laid the foundation, although Szocs was

pushed all the way by Sayali Wani, who produced one of her finest performances of the season before eventually falling short.

Playing only for pride, the Prometheans used all the six available players — a rarity in UTT. Captain Ma-

nav Thakkar delivered his team's most assured display, but even he could not deny the in-form Abhinandh P.B. a crucial game. The youngster's aggressive hitting off both wings in the closing stages of the third game capped another composed outing.

With Challengers, HVR Kolkata Thunder Blades and defending champion U Mumba TT already through, the final league tie on Thursday will determine the fourth semifinalist. Dabang Delhi TTC must win at least nine games against PBG Pune Jaguars to qualify, while Pune requires an unlikely 12-point haul. If the contest goes

down to the final game, Ahmedabad APL Pipers will progress to the semifinals.

The result: Dempo Goa Challengers bt UP Prometheans 10-5 (Alvaro Robles bt Sudhanshu Grover 11-7, 11-5, 11-4, Bernadette Szocs bt Sayali Wani 11-3, 9-11, 11-9, Abhinandh P.B. & Szocs bt Richardo Walther & Swastika Ghosh 11-9, 11-10, 11-9, Abhinandh lost to Manav Thakkar 8-11, 7-11, 11-8, Syndrela Das lost to Yangzi Liu 11-10, 7-11, 6-11) **Standings:** Dempo Goa Challengers 56 points (6 ties); HVR Kolkata Thunder Blades 49 (6); U Mumba TT 48 (6); Ahmedabad APL Pipers 45 (6); Dabang Delhi TTC 36 (5); PBG Pune Jaguars 34 (5); UP Prometheans 32 (6).

INBRIEF



Philipsen wins Tour de France 17th stage

Jasper Philipsen took a dominant victory in a reduced bunch sprint at the end of the Tour de France's Alpine 17th stage on Wednesday. Set up by a strong lead-out from his former World champion teammate Mathieu van der Poel, Philipsen finished several bike lengths ahead of Mauro Schmid and Olav Kooij, who had each already won a stage at the Tour. Race leader and defending champion Tadej Pogacar came home safely in the main peloton just under nine minutes later.

Lakshya hits unbeaten ton as India U-19 dominates

Opener Lakshya Raichandani hit his second century of the series to help India U-19 consolidate its position on day three of the second Youth Test against Sri Lanka U-19 in Colombo on Wednesday.

The scores: India U-19 411 & 208/3 decl. in 40.2 overs (Lakshya Raichandani 100 n.o., Manal Chauhan 51 n.o) vs Sri Lanka U-19 148 in 52.1 overs & 155/4 in 36 overs (Senuja Wekunagoda 64, Vimath Dinsara batting 55, C. Venkata 3/25).

Sindhu beats Unnati; Ayush upsets World No. 11 Farhan

P.V. Sindhu overcame a challenge from teenage compatriot Unnati Hooda to progress to the second round, while Ayush Shetty produced a stunning upset by knocking out World No. 11 Alwi Farhan in the opening round of the China Open in Changzhou on Wednesday.

The results (first round): Women: P.V. Sindhu bt Unnati Hooda 21-14, 9-21, 21-10. **Men:** Ayush Shetty bt Alwi Farhan 17-21, 21-5, 21-17. **Doubles:** Liang Wei Keng & Wang Chang bt Hariharan Amsakarunan & M.R. Arjun 21-16, 21-7. **Mixed doubles:** Feng Yan Zhe & Huang Dong Ping bt Rohan Kapoor & Ruthvika Shivani Gadde 21-9, 21-16; Guo Xin Wa & Chen Fang Hui bt Dhruv Kapila & Tanisha Crasto 21-18, 21-18.

Hetmyer takes WI over the line in a nail-biting finish

Shimron Hetmyer held his nerve in the run chase to make an unbeaten 69 and steer West Indies to a two-wicket win over New Zealand on Tuesday in the fifth and final One-Day International in Barbados. New Zealand took the series 3-2.

The scores: New Zealand 268/9 in 50 overs (Latham 69, Kelly 64, Young 56) lost to West Indies 269/8 in 47.3 overs (Hetmyer 69, Rutherford 61; Lennox 3/35, Duffy 3/67). **Toss:** West Indies. **PoM:** Hetmyer.

LIVE TELECAST

▼ **CW 2026 (Pre-Event Matches):** Sony Sports Ten 2 & LIV, 2 p.m.; **Opening Ceremony:** Sony Sports Ten 2 & LIV, 12.30 a.m. (Friday)
Zimbabwe vs India: First T20I, Unite8 Sports 1, 2 & FanCode, 4.30 p.m.

Anahat and Aryaveer advance in World junior squash

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Anahat Singh and Aryaveer Dewan registered facile wins to enter the pre-quarterfinals of the World squash junior individual championships in Ontario, Canada.

Women's top seed Anahat brushed aside Hong Kong's Pui Yin Chole Lo in straight games in the round-of-32, and will next meet Malaysian Doyce Ye San Lee.

Aryaveer eased past South African Joseph Feast and will take on American Yaseen Shalaby next.

However, Gurveer Singh, Yusha Nafees, Saanvi Kalanki, Rudra Singh and Anika Dubey bowed out after losing to higher seeded opponents.

The results (round of 32): Men: Aryaveer Dewan bt Joseph Feast (RSA) 11-4, 11-3, 11-3; Adam Hawal (Egy) bt Gurveer Singh 11-6, 11-8, 11-3; Nickhileswar Moganasundharam (Mas) bt



In focus: Anahat brushed aside Hong Kong's Pui Yin. WORLD SQUASH
Yusha Nafees 11-9, 11-7, 11-8.
Women: Savannah Moxham (Bel) bt Saanvi Kalanki 11-7, 11-4, 11-2; Barb Sameh (Egy) bt Rudra

CHESS

C. Shyam Sundar
CHENNAI

A draw was enough for Alireza Firouzja in the seventh and final round of the Chennai Grand Masters on Wednesday as the Frenchman walked away with the title in a strong field.

Firouzja's 41-move stalemate also ended his opponent Arjun Erigaisi's chances of fighting for first place.

Clearing the path

The loss suffered by Uzbekistan's Nodirbek Abdusattorov at the hands of Dmitry Andreikin (Russia)



Toast of the town: Firouzja was a crowd favourite after going all the way. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

cleared the path for Firouzja as the 23-year-old emerged champion with 4.5 points.



Firouzja entered the final round as the sole leader, half a point ahead of Arjun and Abdusattorov.

While Arjun needed a win to overtake him, Abdusattorov had to beat Andreikin and hope the top-

board encounter ended in a draw to force a playoff.

Andreikin proved to be the surprise packet, taking the runner-up spot with four points after remaining unbeaten.

Firouzja, who didn't lose a game through the week, received ₹25 lakh for his title-winning effort while Arjun took the third spot, followed by Abdusattorov and M. Pranesh. World champion D. Gukesh held Hans Niemann (USA) to a draw and finished with the wooden spoon (two points). He narrowly avoided slipping out of the 2700-club, thanks to the stalemate; the 20-year-old, who had lost his previous two games, settled for a 19-move draw.

Nihal Sarin, who began with four straight draws, appeared to lose steam towards the business end and wound up with 3.5 points despite a well-crafted win against Arjun in the penultimate round. The fifth-place finish was a creditable performance by Pranesh, the lowest-rated player in the event who handed Gukesh a shock defeat.

The results: D. Gukesh 2 drew with Hans Niemann (USA) 3; Nihal Sarin 3.5 drew with M. Pranesh 3.5; Alireza Firouzja (Fra) 4.5 drew with Arjun Erigaisi 4; Dmitry Andreikin (Rus) 4 beat Nodirbek Abdusattorov (Uzb) 3.5.

Final standings: 1. Firouzja, 2. Andreikin, 3. Arjun, 4. Abdusattorov, 5. Pranesh, 6. Nihal, 7. Niemann, 8. Gukesh.

Niemann takes a dig at Gukesh



No holds barred: Niemann has landed himself in trouble quite a few times due to his straight-talking. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

C. Shyam Sundar
CHENNAI

American Grandmaster Hans Niemann is known more for controversies than his exploits on the board.

He was involved in a public feud with World No. 1 Magnus Carlsen over the cheating allegations levelled against him by the Norwegian. Despite his achievements and avowed ambition to become the best player on the planet, his straight-talking seems to put him in a spot more often than not.

After the end of the Chennai Grand Masters here, the 23-year-old took a dig at reigning World champion D. Gukesh and his predecessor Ding Liren, saying that they had never been the best players in spite of winning the game's top prize.

"The main reason we've seen Ding and Gukesh do

poorly is that they were never the best players in the world. Not even close to it," Niemann said on Wednesday.

He also criticised the World Championship format with "limited number of games" and said that it does not necessarily identify the strongest player over a sustained period. Despite that, Niemann felt Uzbekistan's Javokhir Sindarov was a deserving challenger for the title.

As for the match itself, he opined that Gukesh – whose confidence has been dented by a succession of poor results – could return to form with a bright start.

"If he starts well, regains his confidence and takes control, his prime form could return. But if he starts poorly, it is just going to be a reminder of all the bad results. In one match of 14 games, anything can happen."

India faces spirited Zimbabwe as Shreyas' search for maiden win as skipper continues

INDIA IN ZIMBABWE

Press Trust of India
HARARE

Shreyas Iyer will be eager to earn his first win as India captain when his young team eyes course correction against a spunky Zimbabwe side that is expected to fight hard during the three-match T20I series starting on Thursday here.

Having lost six of his first seven games as skipper in the series defeats to Ireland and England, the contests against Zimbabwe gives Shreyas a chance to get the house in order. A series win against the host would be the expected outcome while a defeat could unnerve the dressing room which has the 15-year-old Vaibhav Sooryavanshi.

For this short tour, India will have a stop-gap head coach in VVS Laxman, whose personality is diametrically opposite to the combative Gautam Gambhir. The spotlight will once again be on 'Boy Wonder' Sooryavanshi as he is set to open in all three games alongside Abhishek Sharma, given the absence of Sanju Samson.

The Harare Sports Club ground will bring back fond memories for both



Happy place: Abhishek must have fond memories of Harare Sports Club, having scored his first T20I ton at the venue. ANI

Abhishek and Sooryavanshi. The Punjab opener made his international debut here and scored his first T20I ton in his second appearance. For Sooryavanshi, this is the venue where he hammered a hapless England U-19 team with 175 in the junior World Cup final earlier this year.

The series was supposed to be an opportunity to experiment with a new-look bowling attack, but it has turned into a must-win affair for India due to recent debacles.

The afternoon games on pitches here, which always have a bit of juice and carry, can pose problems for most of the Indian batters. Blessing Muzarabani and Richard Ngarava, two tall and potent fast bowlers, have the ability to cause chaos.

Laxman's strategy, therefore, will be interesting to watch. The batting position of vice-captain Tilak Varma and the selection of 'all-rounders' – among Shivam Dube, Suryansh Shedge and Harsh Dubey – in the XI will be closely monitored.

Teams (from): Zimbabwe: Sikandar Raza (Capt.), Brian Bennett, Ryan Burl, Tanaka Chivanga, Ben Curran, Brad Evans, Wessly Madhevere, Tadiwanashe Marumani, Wellington Masakadza, Blessing Muzarabani, Dion Myers, Richard Ngarava, Newman Nyamhuri, Milton Shumba, Tafadzwa Tsiga. **India:** Shreyas Iyer (Capt.), Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, Abhishek Sharma, Ishan Kishan, Tilak Varma, Shivam Dube, Harsh Dubey, Suryansh Shedge, Yash Thakur, Prince Yadav, Mayank Yadav, Ashok Sharma, Ravi Bishnoi, Prabhsimran Singh, and Rinku Singh.

Match starts at 4:30 p.m. IST.

Fear of failure has no place in this team: Shreyas

Press Trust of India
HARARE

India captain Shreyas Iyer wants his players to play fearless cricket and not be weighed down by criticism after the team's disappointing run in England, saying the recent setbacks have only brought the squad closer ahead of the three-match T20I series against Zimbabwe.

India arrives in Zimbabwe after enduring a winless white-ball tour of England and Ireland, but Shreyas said the team has identified the areas it needs to improve on.

"We had a rough patch in England, but there were a lot of positives. We got to know what we have to build as a team going forward, what kind of presence of mind, awareness and adaptability we need once we step onto the field," Shreyas said on the eve of the opening T20I here.

"Some of us are playing here for the first time, so the quicker we adapt, the better results we will get."

"I don't think we should fear failure because when you have such thoughts at the back of your mind, then you play to save yourself."

"When you don't have that fear, you can get the best out of yourself."

Indian boys beat Pakistan, Oman in youth hockey5s; girls drub Uzbekistan

Press Trust of India
MUSCAT

The Indian sub-junior boys' team maintained its winning run, outplaying Pakistan and Oman in the Elite Pool of the FIH Youth Hockey5s Asian Championship here.

Led by Ketan Kushwaha, India first registered an emphatic 14-0 win over Oman, with the skipper scoring four goals.

Ashish Tani Purti struck a hat-trick, while Rahul Yadav and Shahrulkh Ali scored braces.

Prahalad Rajbhar, Karan Gautam and Romit Pal also found the back of the net.

Against Pakistan, India prevailed 7-4, with Karan Gautam completing a hat-trick. Rahul Yadav, Prahalad Rajbhar, captain Kushwaha and Romit Pal were the other scorers for India.

Aslam Muhammad Farhan, Adeel and Usman Muhammad scored for Pakistan.



Good show: While the boys bested Pakistan 7-4, the girls routed Uzbekistan 16-0. X@THEHOCKEYINDIA



The sub-junior girls, meanwhile, were held to a 2-2 draw by China before thrashing Uzbekistan 16-0 in another Elite Pool match.

Trailing for most of the contest after Chen Ge put China ahead, India fought back through Nousheen Naz, who scored twice to give her side the lead.

However, Jiaxin Guo netted a late equaliser to earn China a share of the points.

India then rounded off the day with a dominant

16-0 win over Uzbekistan, Nousheen scoring four goals.

Sandeepa Kumari and captain Sweety Kujur struck hat-tricks, while Diya and Pushpa Manjhi added braces.

Kiran Ekka and Nilam Topno also got on the scoresheet.

The tournament serves as a qualifier for the inaugural FIH Youth Hockey5s World Cup.

The results: Boys: India 14 (Ashish Tani Purti 1, 16, 19, Rahul

Yadav 2, 12, Shahrulkh Ali 3, 13, Ketan Kushwaha 6, 11, 15, 20, Prahalad Rajbhar 9, Karan Gautam 15, Romit Pal 18) bt Oman 0.

India 7 (Karan Gautam 5, 9, 19, Rahul Yadav 3, Prahalad 10, Kushwaha 11, Romit 11) bt Pakistan 4 (Aslam Muhammad Farhan 6, Adeel 8, Usman Muhammad 10, 16).

Girls: India 2 (Nousheen Naz 16, 17) drew with China 2 (Chen Ge 4, Jiaxin Guo 19).

India 16 (Sandeepa Kumari 2, 6, 20, Diya 3, 17, Nousheen 6, 9, 15, 16, Kiran Ekka 8, Sweety Kujur 10, 13, 20, Pushpa Manjhi 11, 13, Nilam Topno 18) bt Uzbekistan 0.

commonwealth
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GLASGOW 2026



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GETTY IMAGES

P.K. Ajith Kumar

That day is still fresh in memory. Because that innings is fresh in memory.

The winter was setting in at Raipur. The Shaheed Veer Narayan Singh Stadium, some 20 kms away from the city, looked more imposing than usual as it was virtually empty. There were hardly any spectators for the Senior Women's T20 Challenger Trophy back in 2022.

It was a pity that Yastika Bhatia's unbeaten 99 for India-D against India-C was watched only by a few. It was a masterclass in T20 batting. She was technically correct, played proper cricketing shots, chose the right balls to hit, and struck at a rate of 162.

The only thing she got wrong was counting the balls: otherwise, she would have completed her century. She may have missed the hundred by just one run, but those who watched that innings may not have forgotten it in a hurry. It remains one of the very best in the domestic game over the last few years. Yastika, it was obvious, would go far.

She may have taken her time, but she has gone far. All the way to the Lord's honours board, in fact. The 25-year-old became the first woman to reach there by scoring a Test century.

The hundred consisted of all those elements which the Raipur innings had: technique, lovely shots, and ability to choose the right balls to hit. Of course, the occasion was bigger. It was a Test match, that too a historic one – the first-ever women's Test at cricket's more revered venue. The bowling was much stronger: the Laurens – Bell and Filer – with their seam speciality, another quick in Issy Wong and spinners in Sophie Ecclestone and Mady Villiers.

Crucial performance

Yastika's 113 helped India declare its second innings with the bowlers assured of four sessions in their bid to bundle England out. They needed only two and Indian women's cricket recorded one of its greatest triumphs of all time – a Test win at Lord's by 270 runs.

It was the greatest moment in Yastika's professional life. "The best is yet to come," she would say. But, this one will remain special for several reasons, and we are not just talking about the Lord's honours board. This was her first-ever century for India. It came after a terrible ACL injury and the long, difficult rehabilitation process.

Shortly after the Test, in which she also kept wickets, Yastika looked back at that tough period. She was honest and spoke at length. Her face and eyes told what she had gone through.

"I started from scratch after the injury," said the southpaw. "For the first two months after the surgery, I took total rest. From there, I had to come back. All the muscles in my left leg had been lost in those two months. So after that, I had to start afresh."

The rehabilitation stage began afterwards. "Each muscle you have to train for... the muscles around the knee," she said. "And then slowly there would be progress. Not in one or two days, surely. It was very frustrating to miss out on big tournaments (including the ODI World Cup that India went on to win at home)."

Staying positive

Yastika, however, remained confident. "I had the belief in myself that I could come back from this injury," she said. "The people around me also helped me keep a very positive frame of mind. I was able to do rehab one day at a time."

What did she first do when she finally got to the ground at last? "I was keeping wickets. I just did catching practice, there was no batting; I was very happy. That

day, I was like a little kid smiling the whole day. I was glad that I could keep after four months. Those moments are priceless; I felt the love of the game again. Whatever setbacks you have, how deep that setback is... the love for the game, the belief in yourself – those are very, very crucial," she said. "That will help you to come out from rock bottom and rise once again."

Support system

The top-order batter is grateful to those who stood by her during those difficult days. "A lot of people have helped me behind the scenes," she said.

"My family – my mother, father and sister – they have been the biggest support. My coaches and trainers back home and also the support staff and teammates here in England... they have all backed me. And those at the BCCI Centre of Excellence (CoE), where I underwent the rehab... the surgeons, doctors who took care of my surgery. All of them played a crucial role. My comeback wouldn't have been possible without them."

Then there is a familiar name – Smriti Mandhana, the fellow stylish left-hander with whom Yastika shared a crucial second-wicket partnership in the second innings at Lord's. Smriti, who had also gone through the trauma of an ACL injury, had some advice for her teammate.

"I had a conversation with Smriti. She just looked at me and said: 'This is going to be a turning point in your career,'" Yastika recalled. "She said that because she had faced similar injuries or setbacks. She had learned so much about everything... little,

little things in rehab and in cricket. It completely changed her. She said that my entire mindset, too, would change.

"She said: 'Your game will go to a different level.' She could sense that. We had a few chats during my rehab; the other players were at a camp. I was a little nervous about how things would go. But she said: 'Keep doing your hard work. You are a sincere kid. You are a good human. Just keep working hard and your time will come one day.'"

That day did come. Smriti was there at Lord's to watch it from the sidelines and had been with Yastika out in the middle for a large part of her innings.

It was lovely to watch both of them bat together. Smriti is among the most stylish batters in women's cricket. Yastika, too, is elegant and can play gorgeous strokes.

And Yastika loves batting with Smriti. "You learn so much from her," she said. "Her mindset is very good: she always thinks positively and takes on the bowlers, but in a subtle way. I always look up to her. We have good camaraderie and I enjoy batting with her."

A moment to remember

Looking back at her historic century, Yastika said: "It is unbelievable because I was in a very different place six months ago. If you had told me that I would have my name on the honours board at Lord's, I wouldn't have believed it. But I was taking small steps to that place and I have worked really hard.

My family's support has been there since the beginning."

More than her hundred, she wanted to ensure India had enough runs on the board.

"We had to make a big score at a good rate so that we would have enough time to take England's 10 wickets," said Yastika.

"That was on my mind. I always play my best when I play for the team. I never think about my own score. Playing for the country is a matter of pride. You must have seen my celebration; I kissed the flag on my helmet. I am proud that I could do it for my country."

She could serve the country with both gloves – the batting as well as keeping ones – for years to come. Her class has to be acknowledged, and she deserves a long run.

Missing out

Interestingly, Yastika is not part of the squad for the Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya, Japan, starting September 19. She is the only player to be dropped from the team that played at the T20 World Cup in England, where India was knocked out in the group stage.

THE GIST

In the Lord's match, Yastika's 113 helped India declare its second innings with the bowlers assured of four sessions in their bid to bundle England out

Smriti, who had also gone through the trauma of an ACL injury, helped the fellow southpaw during her comeback

Interestingly, the 25-year-old is not part of the squad for the Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya, Japan, starting September 19



I started from scratch after the injury. But I had the belief in myself that I could come back

YASTIKA
India wicketkeeper-batter



Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Compensation for persons killed in Sikkim tunnel blast

5 in ₹ lakh, per person. The National Hydroelectric Power Corporation Limited (NHPC) has announced an ex gratia payment of ₹5 lakh to the next of kin of each person killed in the tunnel blast at its under-construction Teesta Stage-VI Hydroelectric Project in Sikkim. Rescue operations are continuing round the clock. Of the 25 personnel trapped in the tunnel, 13 bodies have been recovered so far. PTI

Hamlets in flood-hit Kargil where water supply was restored

22 The administration restored drinking water supply in 22 most flash flood-affected areas of Kargil district through temporary arrangements, while permanent restoration of damaged infrastructure is under way on a war footing, officials said. The recent floods caused extensive damage to infiltration galleries, collection chambers, pipelines and headworks. PTI

Number of deaths in Congo due to the Ebola outbreak

999 At least 999 people have died in the Democratic Republic of the Congo's Ebola outbreak, with 2,473 cases recorded since it was declared on May 15. Health officials say it is the fastest Ebola outbreak on record, with no approved vaccines for the Bundibugyo virus. Around 80% of new cases are linked to unknown transmission chains. PTI

The population figures in Cuba in 2025

9.4 million. Cuba's population fell to 9.4 million in 2025, down from 9.7 million a year earlier and just over 10 million in 2023, extending a downward trend driven by an unprecedented wave of migration amid the country's prolonged economic crisis. Cuba also has Latin America's oldest population, with people aged over 60 accounting for 27% of its residents. AFP

Sri Lanka's export earnings in January-June 2026

9.012 in \$ billion. Sri Lanka's export earnings crossed USD 9.012 billion during the first half of 2026, marking the first time that the exports have exceeded USD 9 billion mark in the January-June period. The total was more than 8% higher than the same period last year. PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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Are pellet guns being used at protests?

Pellet guns are used by police and military worldwide as a non-lethal crowd-control measure. They were last known to have been used during the 2024 farmers' protest along the Punjab-Haryana border. Though police denied their use, farmer leaders had alleged that several people were injured.

EXPLAINER

Vijaita Singh

The story so far:

At least one of the 80 protesters injured in police action during the march to Parliament on Monday (July 20), called by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) sustained pellet gun injuries. The victim identified as Shaikh Irshad Mansoori (25), a resident of Gurugram, underwent surgery at a government hospital to remove the pellets lodged under his eye. Most pellets were lodged in the upper part his body.

Another video of a woman being stunned by a “shock baton,” also emerged on Tuesday (July 21). The use of pellet guns and shock batons against civilian protesters, appears to be the first in Delhi.

What are pellet guns?

Pellet guns, whose technical name is ‘pump action guns’, are a form of non-lethal crowd-control method used by police and military worldwide. The other popular measures are tear gas, water cannon, pepper spray and taser guns among others.

Pellet guns are also popular in hunting and pest control. Intended to immobilise an individual, they are effective over short ranges of up to 500 yards but when fired from close quarters can be lethal, particularly when sensitive parts like the eyes are hit. The pellets can penetrate soft tissues.

What happened during the July 20 protest in Delhi?

There are standing instructions to open minimal fire at protesters and if necessary “below their waist.” A cartridge of a pellet gun contains a few hundred pellets made of lead, which disperses a few hundred metres when fired. Pellets can be of various shapes either like ball bearings or irregular. They are manufactured at the Ordinance Factory, Ishapore.



While Delhi Police has denied its use against protesters, pellet guns are part of the RAF's gear. ANI

While the Delhi Police have denied its use against protesters, pellets guns and shock batons are part of the gear of the Rapid Action Force (RAF) – the anti-riot unit under the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) – which was deployed alongside police personnel on July 20 and continues to be deployed near the Jantar Mantar protest site.

On Monday, the victim Shaikh Irshad Mansoori was hit near Palika Bazaar by a RAF official. His friend said that there are around 30-40 injuries on his face and across his body. Four of them, including one in the neck, had penetrated deeply, which is why he underwent surgery.

Originally from Jabalpur in Madhya Pradesh, Mr. Mansoori works at a private company in Gurugram and was attending the protests in solidarity. He also had some visa-related work in New Delhi, which he was supposed to finish after the protest.

What is the first known usage of pellet guns?

Pellet guns were first deployed in Jammu

and Kashmir after Kashmir Valley's summer unrest of 2010 that claimed the lives of 112 protesters in police firing. The then Congress-led government at the Centre deployed pellet guns as a “non-lethal” measure to avoid civilian fatalities.

After violent protests broke out in the Kashmir Valley post July 8, 2016 – when the Hizbul Mujahideen (HM) commander Burhan Wani was killed in an encounter with security forces – several people were blinded due to injuries inflicted by pellet guns, used by the CRPF as a crowd control measure.

Why were its specifications changed?

In 2016, the BJP-PDP government faced severe criticism for using pellet guns, with several political parties asking for its complete withdrawal. Due to the use of pellet guns, 13 people were killed in 2016 and more than 250 were injured, while some lost their vision.

In 2017, a year later, the first batch of less lethal “plastic bullets” were dispatched to the Kashmir Valley. The

plastic bullets were tested at the Terminal Ballistics Research Laboratory (TBRL) in Chandigarh and could be fired from the weapons that the security forces already possessed. Instead of metal, this round of ammunition had a plastic head.

In 2016, 1,022 CRPF personnel were also injured in stone-pelting by protesters. Of these, 956 were injured in the Valley between July 8 and 16 during the unrest.

What is the last definitively known use of pellet guns in the country?

They were last known to have been used during the 2024 farmers protest at Khanauri and Shambhu barriers along the Punjab-Haryana border. Though the police denied using pellet guns, farmer leaders had alleged that several persons were injured.

In 2023, they were used against protesters in the ethnic-strife torn Manipur, leading to a massive public outrage.

What about shock batons?

Shock batons are also a part of the RAF personnel gear.

In 2021, the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA), through the Border Security Force (BSF), prescribed Qualitative Requirements (QRs) for handheld ‘Shock Batons’ intended for self-defence and operational use by security personnel. It said that the equipment should be light weight, with a maximum weight of 1 kg and a length of 450 mm to 700 mm, ensuring ease of carriage and handling. It must be constructed from high-impact resistant material, capable of functioning reliably in temperatures ranging from -20°C to +50°C and offering a minimum level of water resistance.

The shock baton should have a service life of at least five years and be powered by a rechargeable battery. Additional requirements include the capability to deliver at least 1,000 quarter-second shock bursts on full charge, thereby ensuring sustained operational effectiveness in field conditions.

THE GIST



At least one of the 80 protesters injured in police action during the march to Parliament on Monday, called by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) sustained pellet gun injuries.



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Where does the law stand on internet shutdowns?

What questions arise following the internet shutdown in Delhi during the CJP protest?

Rizmi Lia M.

The story so far:

Mobile internet services were shut down in parts of Central Delhi during the ‘Chalo Sansad’ protest organised by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP). Thousands of people gathered on the opening day of the Parliament's Monsoon Session, to demand the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan following the NEET paper leaks and irregularities in the CBSE school examination process. The internet shutdown, which remained in place until the evening, drew condemnation from the Internet Freedom Foundation (IFF) and the Software Freedom Law Centre, India (SFLC).

What is an internet shutdown?

According to web rights advocacy organisation Access Now, an internet shutdown is defined as “an intentional

disruption of internet or electronic communications, rendering them inaccessible or effectively unusable, for a specific population or within a location, often to control the flow of information.” They take many forms, from full network disruptions to slowing down internet speed or blocking platforms.

Most internet shutdowns are ordered when large numbers of people are expected to gather for political reasons, peaceful demonstrations, violent protests or religious celebrations, according to the International Federation of Journalists.

Under Section 20(2)(b) of the Telecommunications Act, 2023, telecommunication services may be suspended only on the occurrence of a public emergency or in the interest of public safety, on the grounds specified in that provision, and for reasons recorded in writing. “A protest, by itself, is not a lawful ground for suspending internet services. Under Section 20(2) of the Telecommunications Act, 2023, a

suspension may be ordered only during a public emergency or in the interest of public safety, and only for specified purposes such as maintaining public order. The order must be reasoned, published, limited in area and duration, and issued by the competent authority under the Telecommunications Suspension Rules, 2024. The government must also consider whether less restrictive measures would be sufficient,” said Apar Gupta, Advocate and Founder of the Internet Freedom Foundation.

Which law governs internet shutdowns?

Internet shutdowns in India were earlier governed by Section 5(2) of the Indian Telegraph Act, 1885 and the Temporary Suspension of Telecom Services (Public Emergency or Public Safety) Rules, 2017. These have now been replaced by Section 20 of the Telecommunications Act, 2023 and the Telecommunications (Temporary Suspension of Services) Rules, 2024.

Despite the updated legal framework, a review by the Digital Defenders Network found that several shutdown orders issued by State governments since late 2024 continue to invoke the Indian Telegraph Act, 1885 and the 2017 Rules.

For instance, the Secretary, Home Department, Uttar Pradesh, issued an internet suspension order applicable to the district of Bareilly on October 2, 2025, invoking Section 7 of the Telegraph Act read with Rule 2(1) of the 2017 Rules.

By continuing to rely on these outdated provisions, some States appear to have bypassed the procedural safeguards introduced under the 2024 Rules.

The current suspension order accessed by *The Hindu* as released by the Ministry of Home Affairs, was imposed across 150 cell sites according to an Industry source. It stated that the order was imposed under Clause (b) of Sub-section (2) of Section 20 of The Telecommunication Act, 2023 read with 2024 Rules.

Where does India stand in terms of internet shutdowns?

India continues to record one of the highest numbers of internet shutdowns in the world. Access Now's 2025 report recorded 65 shutdowns across 12 States and Union Territories.

Jammu & Kashmir has recorded the highest number of internet shutdowns in the country, with about 449 since 2012, followed by Rajasthan (115) and Manipur (62), as per the SFLC Internet Shutdown

Tracker. India has recorded about 24 shutdowns in 2026 (as of July 22).

What limits has the SC placed?

In *Anuradha Bhasin v. Union of India* (2020), the Supreme Court held that access to the internet is closely connected to the freedoms of speech and trade under Articles 19(1)(a) and 19(1)(g).

The Court held that any shutdown must be backed by law, pursue a legitimate objective, be necessary and proportionate, and be the least restrictive measure available. Orders must also be limited in scope and duration, accompanied by detailed reasons, published and reviewed by a competent committee. The Court observed that “complete broad suspension of telecom services, be it the internet or otherwise, must be considered by the State only if ‘necessary’ and ‘unavoidable’.

Can orders be challenged in court?

Yes. A shutdown may be challenged before a High Court under Article 226 or, in an appropriate case, before the Supreme Court under Article 32. Courts can examine whether the order was lawful, proportionate and properly limited in area and duration.

“Indefinite suspensions are unlawful. The government must publish its orders and provide reasons capable of judicial review. Under the 2024 Rules, a suspension order cannot remain in force for over 15 days,” Mr. Gupta said

